EL

written by

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Fourth Draft

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1 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - MORNING** 1

EL (14), a scrappy teen, slouches on the right-most cushion of the three cushioned couch, her cellphone ready for use in her hands. An occasional squirm or twitch works its way through her. Is she unconscious? Conscious? I assumed she was scrolling on her phone until I got to the vines

Behind her the morning sun fights through the fast moving clouds and air conditioning disturbed blinds.

Vines thick and thin crawl out from underneath the couch, and wrap their tendrils around El's ankles, working their way up inch by inch.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Dave got fired.

DAVE (O.S.)
Dave got let go.

Across from El, on two almost touching love seats sit two almost touching adults, SANDRA (40s) and DAVE (40s). Sandra dons formal wear; and Dave...well, Dave is still in his pajamas.

Formal wear like evening gown?

Sandra shoots Dave a look of disapproval. A very very very...very tired look. Very tired.

DAVE
There's a difference.

Are they doing anything while they're sitting, talking? Drinking coffee, on their phones, etc.?

SANDRA
Is there a difference between a fired man's paycheck and a laid off mans's paycheck?

Lol

DAVE
Severance?

SANDRA
I didn't realize that Publix started offering severance packages.

Dave answers with no answer and a sip from a mug of way too hot coffee.

SANDRA
The point is, sweetie, we're taking you out private school.

The vines wrap around her calfs, then clutch her knees. She tries to fight them off, but that just aggravates them further.

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DAVE (O.S.)
We don't want to.

SANDRA (O.S.)
No--

Dave can't make eye contact with El.

DAVE
Not at all.
(Getting choked up)
It breaks my heart.

SANDRA
(rolling eyes)
Sure...And while we're pulling off band aids, fact is that it's been a long time coming. You're always leaving school early. Missing assignments, and quizzes, and tests. How do you think it reflects upon me to have you fail out of my alma matter?

Thinking about audience - so audience doesn't know that he's Dave. Still thinking about him as a third party the the two of them are discussing. Could be a funny reveal moment depending on when/how you have them use each other's names / when the audience "learns" their names

DAVE
(fool's redirection)
Plus! Dave got fir--let go!

Sandra lays her briefcase down onto the coffee table in front of them, opens it just a crack, and hands El a high-school information pamphlet.

El leans forward to try and grab it, but the vines have latched her down onto the couch, and she could barely move. Her arm stuck out--

Can Sandra and Dave see the vines?

Sandra leans a bit closer to bridge the gap.

SANDRA
That's where you'll be going in Spring.

El opens the pamphlet, and scans the panels.

Sandra suggests Dave speak with a clearing of the throat.

Dave, oblivious, takes another sip from his coffee. He's still emotional.

SANDRA
Dave?

DAVE
Ah, yeah. Er.
(MORE)

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48 DAVE (CONT'D)
Uh--also--you're fourteen now. As you know. And your mom--Sandra...it's the minimum wage age--which according to my boss, spans fourteen to forty-three apparently.
50 (awaits the expected laugh)

51 *Not funny.*

52 Sandra opens the briefcase, both sides now flat on the table.

53 She reaches both of her arms into the briefcase, and digs deeper and deeper, until the briefcase nearly swallows her entire torso.

Love this

54 *Gulp...*

55 A leaning tower of a manilla folder comes barreling out of the briefcase, and Sandra dumps it upon Dave's lap.

56 Sandra procures another similar stack, dropping it right near her chair. Sandra sits and readjusts herself, taking a breath.

57 The vines secure El's waist to the couch, and crawl further up toward her chest.

58 DAVE (O.S.) Ha, love "me and your—Sandra—
59 Me and your--Sandra--put together a list of options.

60 SANDRA (O.S.)
61 Sensitive to your problem--

62 DAVE (O.S.) Super love
63 Condition.

64 SANDRA (O.S.)
65 Condition. Right.

66 Sandra and Dave, mirroring each other, push bifocals up the bridges of their noses, and collectively center themselves before--

67 Opening the folders, papers zip out whacking the ceiling and spilling out on the floor. The papers swarm around their heads, little dive bombers on suicide missions. The apartment begins to fill and threatens to swallow them all whole.

68 Sandra and Dave frantically sort through the papers, grabbing at them, then throwing them free, trying to find something--

69 Anything!

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They start to scream options off of randomly grabbed pieces of paper:

SANDRA
Babysitter!

DAVE
She is responsible. But that'd be hard for her, I bet.

SANDRA
Offer constructive criticism. We don't have time for your defeatist attitude.

DAVE
Paper Boy!
(reacting to Sandra's reaction)
Paper girl!

SANDRA
Paper person.

DAVE
(stumbling over each word)
Lawn. Care. Helper. Technician.

The vines, they're around El's throat, and they start to crawl up her face and force their way into her mouth. She fights them.

SANDRA (O.S.)
No. Ugh!...Publix bagger?

DAVE (O.S.)
With the people who fired me?

SANDRA (O.S.)
I thought you got laid off?

The vines crawl down her throat, choking El, her fingers gripping the sofa digging into the fabric.

As Sandra and Dave bicker, the paper swarm overtakes the apartment--a white snowy feedback where the two of them are just distant shadows.

Their argument grows dull and fades as a rising sound of barking dogs comes to overpower everything.

The vines retreat. How can we see the vines if the room is filled with folders?

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2 **INT. EL'S BEDROOM** Is this earlier in time? Did El survive the vines? 2

El holds a torn yearbook page photo of JOSEPHINE 'JOE' LOPEZ.

She hides the photo in a book (what book?) on her bookshelf.

3 **EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 3

El shuts the front door on Dave telling her to have a good day and, of course, to be careful.

4 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - PARKING LOT** 4

GARY (32), battles the power of his leashed pit bull, JOJO, as it tries to break free and feast on a huddle of four migrant workers surrounding a pickup truck.

Gary yells at the migrants in Spanish.

Two of the migrants turn on another one, they grab him and force him down onto his knees.

The kneeled migrant prays for his life.

Gary lets Jojo go, and he leaps at the poor praying migrant.

El hustles in the opposite direction, but as she spins on her heels--

A car backing out nearly makes her its victim. The back of the car catches her leg and almost swallows her whole.

She bangs on the car--it screeches to a halt!

El crawls out from underneath the trunk, and walks over to the Driver's door.

Sandra texts on her phone behind the wheel. She blows El off, continues backing out, then off toward the exit.

The sound of car alarms grows louder.

A yellow race-car careens into the parking lot, the yellow race-car and Sandra just about collide in high impact carnage, but the driver of the yellow race-car has complete control, missing Sandra, spinning out and on, burning and ripping rubber passed and beyond El.

The bass from the yellow race-car sets off the car alarms of every car it passes. It spins and parks, the passenger door facing the apartment complex.

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SHEEN (23) gets out of the car screaming her head off as she walks off to her apartment. FRANK (28), donning a yellow leather outfit and helmet, barrels out of the car after her, but she bares him no mind.

He halts before following up to the second floor, flails his arms in exasperation, then retreats to his car.

Just as Frank notices El watching, she continues on her way as nonchalant as possible (a.k.a. not at all).

Frank tails her, crawling a few car lengths behind.

This scene is really cool - not sure why it's here yet but don't feel I need to, seems to show that the world is in chaos

DISSOLVE TO:

5 **EXT. RESIDENTIAL STREET** 5

El hurries down the street. Behind her Frank turns into view.

DISSOLVE TO:

6 **EXT. BUSY STREET** 6

El runs down the street.

Frank turns following her still.

She arrives at the bus stop the same time as the bus and hops on.

7 **INT. BUS** 7

El watches Frank follow her from the rear.

8 **EXT. SCHOOL** 8

Bus pulls away, El bounds toward the building.

Frank screeches down the block at hyper speed.

9 **INT. SCHOOL** 9

El opens the front door, and slams it closed behind her as the sound of the car alarms and the uproarious engine.

Gunshots spray.

Just above El's head, bullet holes let loose beams of light into the darkened entrance way.

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10 **INT. A.M. HOMEROOM** 10

As El enters Homeroom, the bell rings signifying the end of the short attendance taking class.

El fights her way into the room as the kids pour out.

She then fights for the attention of the HOMEROOM TEACHER ignoring her.

HR TEACHER
(annoyed)
You're late. Go to the office. Get a late pass. Again...

11 **INT. SCHOOL OFFICE** 11

El stands before a large desk, an ELDERLY ASSISTANT fills out a late-pass behind said desk.

ELDERLY ASSIST.
Late two mods. Two days detention.
(Finishing up the late-pass)
Detention's in room--
(hands over the late-pass, and makes eye contact)
I don't need to tell <u>you</u> the details, now do I, missy?

12 **INT. CLASSROOM** 12

El enters, disrupting the class, and freezes.

MATH TEACHER
Well?

El hands over her late-pass to the MATH TEACHER, then takes her seat in the class.

She unpacks her bag, pulls out her textbook, carefully places her laptop on the desk.

MATH TEACHER writes some notes on the board.

El opens her laptop.

The screen awakens.

MATH TEACHER (V.O.)
No laptops in class.

MATCH CUT TO:

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13 **EXT. PLAYGROUND - AFTERNOON** 13

On the screen: an almost completed dog walking flyer.

El fiddles with the font.

Distracted, she looks away from her work. In the distance, a cheer squad practices on the sidelines of a football field, while players run practice on the field.

14 **EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD** 14

A human pyramid starts to take shape.

Joe watches one of the football players on the field, NUMBER 55. He goes out for a pass, catches it, and the team cheers.

Joe climbs to the top of the pyramid with ease.

Where'd Number 55 go?

Joe wobbles...

And falls--

Into the arms of Number 55. Joe screams, then laughs, then whacks Number 55 as she hops out of his arms.

JOE
(smiling)
Unhand me, perv!

NUMBER 55
If I didn't hand you, you'd be dead or at least paralyzed.

JOE
Dramatic.

This is interesting but by this point I'm wanting more of El's narrative & not really interested in this Joe/55 interplay unless it comes back around to El

NUMBER 55
What do you think is worse?

JOE
Huh?

NUMBER 55
Dead or paralyzed?

15 **EXT. PLAYGROUND** 15

A mile away, cheerleaders continue to cheer and the boys continue to run drills.

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A spiked volleyball with spikes whacks El in the head--

Her laptop goes flying, ripcording her earbuds out, and knocks her off the bench and into a car behind her, crushing the car on impact and moving it into the street.

? I thought she's in the classroom

MIA (16) and her posse, CHANDLER (16), RUTH (16), and EMILY (16), approach. All the girls are revved up, except Emily, Emily hovers behind the other three. They're all dressed in similar uniforms.

MIA
Ugh! How clumsy!

16 **EXT. BEACH VOLLEYBALL COURT** 16

El digs her laptop out from a mound of sand. She pulls out and tries to untangle thirty feet of headphone cable from an endless sand hole.

Red with anger she shoves her stuff into her backpack.

The bullies stand on one side of the net, arms folded in front and hips cocked.

MIA
I said! "Whoops, that was an accident!" Didn't you hear me? I said sorry. That was an accident.

CHANDLER
Did you hear her?

RUTH
She said sorry.

A crowd of teens all dressed in summer beach wear approach and surround the court. They cheer at the prospect of a fight.

El's knees lock, her anger turns cold, as the circus spins around her.

Another spiky volleyball is tossed into the court. Chandler picks it up, and sets it up for Mia to serve.

Mia spikes it, and it almost hits El, but she moves just in time, throwing herself into the sand, and getting a mouthful.

MIA
Dumb and deaf.

Chandler and Ruth laugh.

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MIA
You hear me, Em? I said she was "dumb and deaf."

EMILY
(sotto voce)
Yeah. Deaf and dumb.

Emily pushes through the crowd and leaves.

MIA
Em?...Em?!

Chandler and Ruth chant "Dumb and deaf!"

El regains her composure, and on the verge of tears also pushes through the crowd surrounding them.

17 **EXT. SCHOOL** 17

Breaking through the wall of onlookers, El wipes tears from her face, then hurries down the street, before re-entering the school.

18 **INT. SCHOOL** 18

El sneaks past the SECURITY GUARD pre-occupied on his cellphone.

She slips into a stairwell, up two flights of stairs, down the hall, and knocks on the door to the school's library and computer lab.

The computer teacher, MS. ROGER (a lady older than any computer), answers. She has a napkin tucked into her shirt.

ROGER
(chewing)
What do you want? It's lunchtime.

EL drops to her knee, wrestle her Bio textbook from her bag, and shows it to Ms. Roger.

ROGER
Oh, you're the one who don't talk. For chrissakes, every single one of you has a problem.

Ms. Roger moves out of the way, allowing El to enter.

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19 **INT. LIBRARY/COMPUTER LAB** 19

El finds a seat out of eyesight of Ms. Roger. She opens up her laptop, pours sand out of it, then makes a few adjustments to her flyer.

ROGER (O.S.)
Remember, no printing! Not in the budget!

El peeks around a colossal ancient PC, and sees Roger looking right at her. She recoils, and hides.

El formulates a plan.

She pulls out pen and paper from her bag, writes a note, and delivers it to Roger.

ROGER
Yes?
(Pulls her glass off)
...this is in the backroom...this is my lunch break too!

And with that Roger is off in a huff.

El hurries back to her computer, and prints the flyer.

As copies print, El keeps watch.

In the midst of the fourth rendering, El hears Roger coming back and is unable to cancel the print-job. She rips the power cord out of the wall.

The printer halts as Roger returns, book in hand.

Roger hands El the book. El feigns disappointment.

ROGER
That is <u>the</u> exact book you asked for.

Roger shows EL what she wrote in the note.

EL grabs the note, and corrects the Dewey decimal number, and returns it to Roger.

Beat.

Roger turns on her heels back to the rumored backroom. El grabs Roger’s shirtsleeve, pulls the note from her hand once more, and scribbles a few more numbers down.

As El starts to write another, Roger grabs the pencil and snaps it in half then storms off to the backroom.

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El plugs the printer back in. It starts up and continues printing. She watches a few more copies print.

Behind her, Roger clears her throat. El slowly turns around trying to slam the “cancel print” button but the printer just keeps on printing.

EL reaches behind her when the print job ends to grab the flyers and then runs to collect her stuff.

20 **EXT. SCHOOL** 20

Hurrying down the road, El counts the flyers printed; they blow in the wind and fold in on themselves as she does so.

1...2...3 (ugh, distorted from the printer shutting off in the middle)...4...5...6...7...8.

El considers tossing the messed up flyer, but reconsiders and shoves the flyers into her bag.

21 **EXT. VARIOUS STREETS** 21

El rushes through the streets. On the run. All cars and people travel the opposite direction with the urgency of doomsday.

She continues to swim upstream, tracking the faces of horror as she passes.

22 **EXT. PUBLIX PARKING LOT** 22

Pandemonium breaks loose. Cars caught in traffic behind enormous exit lines. Civilians trampling one another. Pitchfork brigade has come for whatever is in that Publix.

Police create a barrier.

El slips threw the crowd and past the police--no one notices or cares.

And just as the sliding glass doors open for her, a large panel of glass shatters somewhere close by.

Unfazed, she enters.

23 **INT. PUBLIX** 23

Screams and shouts fill the supermarket.

FLAILING EMPLOYEE runs out from an aisle, and falls at El’s feet, gripping bloody ears.

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Eye roll.

High frequency piercing whine spreads like a siren.

Grasping her ears, El moves from aisle to aisle, taking cover, then checking before leaping.

Closer to the siren's source, louder than before, it shifts in the ear canal, and becomes normalized and interpretable.

HUGH (V.O.)
(takes frequent pauses, sings his words)
Humans. Humans. We're the people who belong here. You heard that right. We belong everywhere in fact. Who doesn't...I suppose some don't. I'm sorry. It was an accident.

Peeking around the aisle, HUGH (78), hovers around a shattered apple sauce spill and the employee trying to clean it up--and trying to stop his ears form bleeding.

HUGH
You got a knack for this. Sorta like it runs in the family. Very proficient. Very, very good mop handling. My daughter laughs at me, she says I have a method for everything. And why shouldn't I? Let me guess, Mexican? Quite the water crisis your people have. Hey, at least you know where you're from, right?

Hugh's head turns toward El, she pulls away in time.

Phew.

Screw this

El leaves, passing the frightened cashiers--

Hangs a flyer on the bulletin board just by the exit.

24 **EXT. PUBLIX - LOCAL NEWS COVERAGE** 24

TALKING HEAD REPORTER. Doesn't matter. During the spiel, El exits Publix and leaves frame.

TALKING HEAD
...second visit today, which is
(MORE)

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TALKING HEAD (CONT'D)
unheard of for a man this age. Deborah, the real question around here, not exactly being said in hushed tones is when will he finally die and leave this community in peace instead of pieces?...

who's "he"? and why does he have so much power

Static. Channel Changes to:

25 **INT. TELEVANGILIZED CHURCH** 25

Bright, white, and gaudy. Crowd mad with holiness. ENTERTAINMENT PREACHER (middle-aged), acting as hype man, riles the crowd further.

JEANNIE (52), on stage, stands behind a large bakery case filled with pastries. Sheen, trying to stand up straight or not pass out, leans on the front of the bakery case, her back to the audience. El waits in the wings.

ENTERTAINMENT PREACHER
Sister Jeannie, our beloved, beloved sister...<u>and</u> top donator, has, out of the goodness of her ever eternal holy heart has brought along with her a soul in desperate need of saving. <u>This</u> ladies and gentleman, is a woman on a path of the lord. Lets not let her down!

Audience cheers.

E. Preacher consecrates Jeannie.

ENTERTAINMENT PREACHER
I give you the blessed power and holy consecration of his heavenly delights for the duration of thirty minutes, amen!

Jeannie feels the power enter her. Her thirty minute countdown appears on the screen.

ENTERTAINMENT PREACHER
(to camera)
If you want to be consecrated like our sister here, call the number below for our rates.
(to Jeannie)
Sister, you're time is ticking.

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E. Preacher steps aside.

JEANNIE
(cuts a roll, toasts it)
I renounce thee Satan! Leave this poor girl--this girl you ravaged and mark with the number of the beast in all its deceiving forms!

SHEEN
Uh, how much longer?

JEANNIE
(buttering the roll)
Almost--Satan! Leave this child now! I command you! In the name of all goodness and heavenliness!
(hands Sheen the bag)
Three bucks even.

26 **INT. BAKERY** 26

Sheen digs for cash in the itty bitty strips of clothes she's wearing.

Turning to leave, she almost knocks into El.

SHEEN
(from loud to a whisper)
Buh. Bye. You. Crazy. Ass. Lady.

Sheen exits, the door's little bell rings.

El steps up to the plate.

JEANNIE
Father, son, and the forever loving Holy Spirit. Don't end up like her, you sweet innocent child! I already have your gingerbread-men ready for you.
(hands bag to El, but doesn't let go)
Would you like to go to church with me this Sunday? Father Daniel has been asking me about you since you last came three months ago. You do know to be lazy in regards to salvation is a sin in and of itself?

Bag tug-o-war continues.

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El gives a mighty tug, and Jeannie releases, sending El falling back onto her behind and sliding across the floor. Her belongings fall and spread out onto the floor.

JEANNIE
I'll call your mother tonight.

Up in a huff!

From her pocket, El pulls out a stack of laminated handwritten cards, shuffles through them to an exact location, and shows the card to Jeannie.

"She is not my mom."

JEANNIE
(as she steps up from behind the counter)
Well now, that is not nice and frankly unbecoming of a lady to suggest. Your mother is a very hard worker. At <u>least</u> one person in every family needs to be. God knows, my father wasn't. I still pray for him everyday. A few Sunday masses will fix you right up.

Next thing next, El collects the spread out flyers(need better words).

Reorganizing, she puts the bakery bag into her backpack.

Jeannie offers a hand to help her up.

JEANNIE
(noticing the flyers)
What do you got there?

With hesitance, El reveals her flyers. Jeannie grabs one from her hands, and the rest fall to the floor once more.

In a huff, El picks them all up again.

El gestures for the flyer, Jeannie ignores her.

Cut your losses.

Back out one...step...at...a...time...

JEANNIE
(returning to behind the counter
Did you make this on the computer?
(MORE)

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JEANNIE (CONT'D)
You know, it's so funny, I've been talking about taking computer classes again for so long now. I should really just do it because I hate to be the person who says something and doesn't ever go through with it. Computers...what a wonderful--yet dangerous--machine.

27 **EXT. BUS STOP** 27

Everything goes quiet and slows down as

Sheen, leaning against a tree,

takes a bite of her buttered roll,

chews,

then forgets she has even been chewing,

starts up chewing again quicker than before,

hard swallow,

coughs,

spits out a loogie--

Rip-roaring bus pulls up with hyper speed, blowing all but one of the flyers out of El's hands.

She tries to chase them in the wind tunnel

but they land in an algae puddle.

Facepalm

Idiot. Moron.

Let 'em go.

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28 **INT. BUS** 28

Sheen's flirting gets her on the bus for free.

El opens a little pouch on her bag with the exact change and dumps it into the dispenser.

HUGH (O.S.)
You think your wife is bad come over to my house! Okay? Me and you, we'll switch. Okay?

No!!!

El hurries to a seat near the back, equal distance between Sheen (far back) and Hugh (right up front next to the driver).

As the bus takes off:

BUS DRIVER
(screaming at Hugh)
Sir, will you please shut up!?

HUGH
What?!

BUS DRIVER
Would you--
(composing himself)
keep it down,please?

HUGH
I sure would mind! I've been quieted enough in my life! We've been quieted enough! Our people. My people!

Hugh quiets down and becomes one with his groceries taking up the seats on both sides of him.

El straightens out her flyer--

it's the one the printer messed up. But it's still legible.

It'll have to do.

Sheen nods off in the back of the bus, one earbud in the other falls out. She comes to, puts the other earbud back in and rocks out for a few measures.

HUGH (O.S.)
(getting louder)
You!...You!...Hey! You!!!

El turns and he's pointing right at her.

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Bummer.

HUGH
Come on and sit over here. Don't make me scream across the bus for you, sweetie.

Pretend to unsee?...unhear?

HUGH
(waving her over)
Come on.

Ugh. Fine.

El moves a few seats closer.

HUGH
Closer. Closer.
(whispering, but not at all)
They don't like Jews talking on this bus. Can you believe it? Silencing me? How times have changed. So sad.
(normal volume a.k.a. very loud)
I said closer.

She slides over a few seats, now spitting distance.

HUGH
Did you know that there was a time, not too long ago mind you, when Jews weren't allowed into Disney? Have you ever been to Disney? I swore to myself, as a father and a Jew, no matter which way or which how that I'd take my girls to Disney. If I had any boys, of course, I would've taken them too. The point is...there was a time when kids would play outside. Open fire-hydrants and play baseball with sticks and then kneel on those same sticks if we didn't make out beds...

DISSOLVE TO:

29 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - AFTERNOON** 29

El, carrying all the grocery bags, and Hugh, her flyer in hand, make their way toward his apartment, up a flight of stairs.

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HUGH
...our nephew trains police sniffing dogs, you know...Why is the letters so small?...The point is, live and let live, but don't take it out of our paychecks. I'm not paying taxes so Joe Shmo can go and get his rocks off. Listen, the point is this...This is my point, and I've been saying this to Rebecca and Erica since they were old enough to hear...

Hugh hands her back the crumpled last flyer, she has to shift all the bags in order to for her to take the flyer back and stuff it into her pocket, crumpling it even further.

El almost drops a bag.

HUGH
Careful! Careful! For chrissakes...if you squish that liverwurst she'll kill you. And I won't hear the end of it. Stupid dog. Can't wait it to croak.

BENJI (the 'stupid dog') comes barreling toward them, yapping it's brain out.

HUGH
Shut it!

Hugh mimes a powerful kick, but he doesn't actually mean to kick the dog. Benji circles El as they come to the front door.

At his front door, BARB (70s), Hugh's wife, awaits with the door open. Hugh pushed passed her and into the house.

BARB
Oh, poor thing! He roped you into helping him. Come on in. Come on in. Put them on the kitchen table please, dear.

30 **INT. HUGH'S APARTMENT - FOYER** 30

El hurries in, the apartment is pitch black. Dumps the bags, not really able to see or make out anything.

She follows the light back to the open front door.

Barb, still waiting by the front door, blocking it, corners El.

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BARB
(holding out a closed fist)
Here, take this.

El holds out her palm, and Barb drops change into her hand.

Metal cash from different lands and different times.

HUGH (O.S.)
(yelling)
She wants to walk the mutt!
For money!

BARB
That's sweet, but I don't want to give him any less chores.
(cackles)

31 **EXT. HUGH'S APARTMENT** 31

Barb allows El to pass.

El exits, notices Sheen letting herself into her apartment across the way.

Barb, careful not to step passed the threshold of the door, beckons El a bit closer with a long and old digit.

El dips her head back into the darkness.

BARB
(whispering to El)
I'd kill to have her youth and looks...and body...

GASP

El stumbles away from the darkness,

Barb fades away,

Benji runs out and into El's arms--

He cries for help!

BARB (O.S.)
Benji!

The dog runs back in--

the door slams closed!

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32 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 32

Tension releases once El closes the door behind her.

DAVE (O.S.)
Honey? Home already?

Tension returns.

Texts Dave: "Half day."

DAVE (O.S.)
Lot of half days this year, huh?
Must be making budget cuts.
(beat)
I was trying to decide what to make for dinner. Does your mom--I mean, Sandra. I know she's not your mom. Can't help but keep messing that up. Sorry.

hmm interesting

(laughs)
Does Sandra hate thighs or breasts, I can't remember?

DISSOLVE TO:

33 **EXT. MAILBOX BAY - AFTERNOON** 33

El flattens out the last remaining distorted flyer agains the side of a large free-standing mailbox.

Tapes the flyer down, real good. Faint voices grow louder.

MYLO (24) approaches with a MALE SHADEBALL (20s) and FEMALE SHADEBALL (20s) in tow. At first, Mylo doesn't notice El, walks right by her.

MYLO (O.S.)
...drop like flies around here. It's crazy, honestly, how many people are dying. On one hand, sucks for them. On the other, all these better and better apartments keep opening up. Eighteen hundred for two bedrooms. Fifteen for one bedroom. Me and my brothers, we mind our business and we mind our own goddamned business. You know what I--

Backpedals.

Made in Highland

MYLO
Yo! Pretty child, what do you think you are doing?
(coming closer)
No advertising no soliciting without approval from the eye...ssssssssssssssssssssss
(pointing to all the cameras, grabs El by the scruff of the neck to make her see)
in the sky. My brother, Julian, would be most displeased.

Riiiiiiiips her last flyer off the mailbox.

RipRipRipRipRips the flyer into a million little pieces.

MYLO
Got it?

Throws them into the air.

High-fives the mister and missus shadeball, and carries on, laughing.

Paper shreds rains down on El.

Takes a knee, and tries to reassemble the once distorted and now shredded and distorted flyer.

And is almost able to fully recreate it--

Wind yanks away a few pieces.

SHARON (40s), head down, occupied by her cellphone, knocks into a crouched El.

SHARON
Watch where you're going!

El falls forward, disturbing the flyer only slightly. She fixes it.

SHARON
(finally looking up from her phone)
Oh, hi, sweetie. what're you doing on the floor? It's dangerous down there.

El moves aside to show her the flyer.

SHARON
Are you an artist or...something?

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El gestures to the text.

SHARON
Dog walking?

El turns to Sharon, and nods--

Final shreds lift off with a single and final gust, fly into the sky up up above.

Typical -_-
Last glimmer of hope
Don't be dramatic.

SHARON
(walking away)
How'd I'd kill to come home from work and not have to walk a damned dog...what a fantasy. Imagine? Let me tell you something, sweetie...
(she looks for El, just catching up, yet doesn't really care if El listens)
...men, better yet, boys--don't grow up. No matter what age. So stay skinny, wear the right bra, and keep 'em young so at least they don't hav'ta pop a friend before dinner. The only difference. And they still won't walk the dog.

34 **EXT. SHARON'S APARTMENT** 34

Halt in front of Sharon's front door.

Sharon touches El's cheek, she gets cute and mousey.

SHARON
Just to prove old Sharon knows what she is talking about...if I go inside and he didn't walk the dog, I'm going to murder him, and then he's going to pay you to walk the dog.

Sharon goes inside her apartment, and smiles as she closes the front door.

Beat.

Bark.

Made in Highland

Muffled screams of a banshee blow the roof off the entire apartment complex.

Everything settles.

Door opens.

Sharon, cigarette in mouth, martini in hand, stands behind the threshold.

SHARON
Congratulations! You get to take care of the simple responsibility you'd think a person who sits around all day drinking creatine and spending my dead husband's money might be able to take care of--
(to the recipient of such kind words)
you worthless piece of--
(puff. sip.)
Neither here nor there.
(loudly)
Come get the dog anytime! You can count on him always being home!

She slams the door closed--

Then re-opens it very quietly.

Sharon sticks out a long manicured finger, beckoning El closer and El of course obliges.

SHARON
You know about the dark web, right? People your age know about that stuff, right?
(based on El's cluelessness)
You don't have to play dumb with me. I'm cool. Super cool. Now, do you think when a hitman takes your money, they actually show up? I'm trying to be proactive--hell, I wish I killed my first husband like they think I did. Didn't kill him. Wish I did. Nine eleven, PTSD, blah blah, survivor's guilt, bang--
(blows her brains out with her finger)
Wanna come in?

El checks the time on her phone.

Made in Highland

Would you look at the time! I gots to go!

35 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - LATE AFTERNOON** 35

El celebrates on her way back up to the second story.

Voices heard nearby grab her attention, two boys fooling around.

OMAR (20) and MICAH (20), two college dudes, make their way to their apartment.

El catches up to them, tails them, but they don't notice her. She awkwardly tries to get their attention as they continue to walk home.

Basic question, but what's motivating her (in general and in this moment)? Does she want friends?
Why does she really need a job?
I'm super interested by the story so far, but I have no idea why people are doing what they're doing. I don't know that I need to know everyone's motivations, but I do wish I had a better sense of El's by now. I like her, but I don't know her well

OMAR
Not ture.

MICAH
True. Very true.

OMAR
Prove it.

MICAH
Someone's phone has all the evidence I need.

OMAR
Someone. Not you!.

MICAH
Listen, it's your bad you suck at FPSs <u>and</u> drinking <u>and</u> getting Lee's number when she was practically begging for you to ask.

OMAR
You're dumb.

MICAH
Why?

OMAR
Because you are.

MICAH
Solid argument.

OMAR
As solid as you're evidence.

Made in Highland

MICAH
Funny.

OMAR
You're funny.

MICAH
You're way funnier.

36 **EXT. COLLEGE KID'S DORM** 36

All three arrive at the front door, El remains unnoticed.

OMAR
Let's ask Zoe.

MICAH
Good. Yeah. Best idea you had all day. I'll ask Zoe.

OMAR
I'll ask Zoe.

MICAH
Dude. I'll ask Zoe.

OMAR
Open the door.

MICAH
You don't have your key?

OMAR
I do.
(finding his key)
And.
(unlocks the door)
I'm...
(opens the door)
asking Zoe.

The boys run in after the other, leaving the door wide open and El standing their left behind.

El unsure what to do, decides to reach in and close the door herself.

Knock. Knock.

ZOE (23) answers. Bubbly and annoyed at the boys arguing somewhere in the apartment.

Made in Highland

ZOE
Hiii!?

El waves, suddenly matching the bubblyness.

Beat.

ZOE
So...what's up?

BO, a young golden retriever, apparently bored with the boys energy, hustles over to the front door and slips right past Zoe.

El eagerly ready to accept him--

When the sun hits his fur, it stings him, he retreats inside yapping.

ZOE
Sorry about that...
(to the boys inside)
Shut up! You're both idiots--thus, you're both wrong!
(to El)
Sorry about that...
(beat)
So...what <u>is</u> up?

El whips out her deck of cards, shuffles through them, and hands over one to Zoe asking for her phone number.

Zoe starts saying her number--

El a few beats behind, grabs her phone, so Zoe starts from the beginning but more slowly this time.

Zoe twirls her hair in confusion as

El texts her:

"Hello! I'm El, your neighbor. Would you be interested in paying me to walk, exercise, and/or groom your pet? I offer different packages at different rates."

El starts to act out the text as Zoe reads it.

ZOE
Oh my god. If this dog needs anything it's a bath and a walk that lasts longer than the trot from the food bowl to his bed.

Excitement swells. The second sale.

Made in Highland

ZOE
Problem is, he's not really my dog.

El gestures to the boys inside.

ZOE
Not their dog either. God, you think they're capable of taking care of an animal? Keith's. Fake alpha with a chinstrap. We don't get along, and I don't think he'd be interested. Sorry.

El, disappointed, makes a move to leave.

ZOE
Hey, you never know, if you come back when Keith is here, he might be into it. I wouldn't get my hopes up.

El waves, a crumpled mouth.

ZOE
Listen...tell ya' what. If you can do this before seven every night before Keith and Jess get home, I could pay you.

El returns, she's smiling now.

ZOE
I mean, the poor thing rots all day. This will be good for him. You have my number, so text me before you gonna swing by.

El gives a thumbs up, backing away. Zoe closes the door.

37 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 37

El comes dancing and hopping past the door.

Backpedals and returns composed, realizing whose door it is.

I shouldn't...

Leaves.

Why shouldn't I?

Returns. Raises a fist to knock...

Made in Highland

Don't be stupid. Bad idea.

Leaves again--

Comes back, hand over eyes, the other hand finally knocks. Breathing heavily before regaining composure once more.

No one answers the door.

El starts to kick her sneakered feet into the ground.

Waiting longer than any human would think to wait.

She gives up and leaves.

Door opens every so slowly and pillars of smoke escape.

El hurries back and great Sheen at the door.

SHEEN
Hey, little chick. Almost didn't see you there.

DISSOLVE TO:

38 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EVENING** 38

El, earbuds in, works on her homework on one end of the kitchen table, and Sandra, guzzling wine, grades homework on the other end of the kitchen table. Dave finishes cooking dinner.

DAVE
Okay ladies, clear the table. Dinner's ready.

SANDRA
I'm never going to finish these papers.

Sandra downs the last gulp of wine from her glass, then moves her work off the table.

DAVE
You always say that and then you always finish.

Sandra taps El on the shoulder.

SANDRA
Clear you stuff. Mister Mom says dinner's ready.

Made in Highland

The table clears, and then El helps Dave set the table. Sandra pours more wine.

The girls take their seats as Dave plates the food, serving Sandra...

SANDRA
Bravo. Not microwave tonight.
(laughs)

He serves El and himself a plate and sits.

SANDRA
So, find any work?

Dave and El look to each other.

DAVE
Who are you asking?

SANDRA
I din't expect you to find a job so soon.

DAVE
I didn't.

SANDRA
Right.

El excited to share her victories, starts to type.

SANDRA
Honestly. And I hate to say this. But, I don't think this dog thing is the best idea. I don't know what your dad was thinking.

"He's not my dad."

But interesting, I just keep wondering who her parents are and who she is (guessing that's an intent?) I like the theme repeating

SANDRA
Problem is, sweetie, that it's not something I think you can handle. It's not you, it's the deadbeats around here. They're scum. Grade A scum...Grade F scum rather. Sleazeballs.
(guuuulp)
I don't know what I'd do to myself if anything ever happened to you.
(to Dave)
You forgot the wine.

Another glass down.

Made in Highland

Dave retrieves the wine.

DAVE
(back at the table, pouring wine, to El)
I think she has a point, sweetie.

Sandra smiles and sips.

DAVE
Maybe we can give her a chance?

SANDRA
A chance to get kidnapped or worse?

DAVE
She already told three different people she'd walk their dogs for them.

SANDRA
Yeah, and what if they don't pay her? What then?

DAVE
They'll have to talk to me.

Gulp. Gulp.

SANDRA
Two weeks probation for both of you.
(to El)
You have to be back before dinner.
(to Dave)
If anything goes wrong...it's on you.

DAVE
What else is new?

SANDRA
Right.

Sandra dumps her food in the trash, and exits.

Dave shoots El a wink, but El's nerves are getting to her.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

Made in Highland

39 **INT. SCHOOL - AFTERNOON** 39

El sits at her desk. The students engage in quiet work. El checks the clock over and over as she tries to focus on reading her book.

The clock ain't moving. It's ticking, but stuck still. Pressure builds and the clock could burst at any moment.

Tick

Focus

Tick

FOCUS

Tick

Calm down...

Tick

Bell.

El's up and the first one out of the room, bouncing off the walls for momentum.

HALLWAY

Running down the hall, she around and between the crowd before the students pour out en masse.

She turns through a door

STAIRWELL

Great image/symbolism here

and gets caught in a long slow line.

Trying to cut through--she's rejected and forced back.

DISSOLVE TO:

HOMEROOM

Bell rings--

Five seconds later, El enters.

HR TEACHER
How it it possible to be late to
(MORE)

Made in Highland

HR TEACHER (CONT'D)
p.m. homeroom?

Clock continues

Tick

Tick

Ticking as the teacher calls roll.

Bell Rings.

HALLWAY

Main exit is blocked. and here

El takes another route.

40 **EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD** 40

Interfering with football practice, El runs through a few drills in order to pass to the other side of the field and continue making good time.

41 **EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - AFTERNOON [CONTINUOUS]** 41

--climbs and hops a large fence, falling into a backyard, rolling into the pool gets soaked

--climbs the next fence, falls into the next yard, but this time almost gets chopped up by a lawnmower

--runs through the backlot of Publix, passing underneath a tractor trailer

--passes the bakery, but returns

--leaves with food, she chomps down on as she runs, pours water on herself as the marathon continues

42 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 42

El bursts in

EL'S BEDROOM

and drops her stuff onto the floor. She checks the time.

3:38PM

Made in Highland

She sets an alarm for two hours from now.

Changes into the workout version of her uniform.

43 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 43

Behind the closed door, ALBIE, Sheen’s pooch, barks and scratches and jumps onto the door.

El pulls a keychain out of her pocket, sorts through the keyring, finds what she’s looking for, then opens the door.

Albie busts out and gives El some much needed affection.

44 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY** 44

Albie leads the way along the second story landing of the apartment complex.

COLLEGE KID'S DORM

Albie barks at the Bo barking at him from behind the door. El knocks.

ZOE (O.S.)
Hold on!

Beat.

Zoe opens up and hands over the leashed Bo.

APARTMENT COMPLEX

Albie and Bo yank El, fighting for the lead. El is having a blast.

SHARON’S APARTMENT

Albie and Bo bark at BELLE, yipping right back from behind the door.

Knock. Knock.

No answer.

Knock. Knock.

KNOCK. KNOCK.

Made in Highland

WALTER (26) answers the door shirtless and in underwear, he's drinking a protein shake from a plastic shaker. He drops a leash on the floor and walks away without making any sort of eye contact or even closing the door.

El attempts to leash Belle as the whole pack of em engage in a playful, yet chaotic, scuffle.

45 **EXT. STREET** 45

The dogs pull El so hard her feet don't quite touch the ground--

Pure bliss.

Bo stops. The other dogs halt a bit past him.

El flies beyond them.

She returns to Bo relieving himself...

El whips a plastic bag out of her pocket, but as soon as Bo's butt puckers up the mush squad keeps on mushing, pulling El away from her neighborly duty.

El fights with all her might back towards the waste, and is able to scoop it up despite the tug-o-war.

46 **EXT. DOG PARK** 46

El and the dogs pull up with a skidding halt--El falls onto the ground due to the sudden stop. The park has five other dogs in the park with their owners.

They fight their way through multiple gated barriers.

When inside the park, El lets the dogs loose.

El walks over to a covered area where the owners congregate. As soon as she steps into their air, she turns and withdraws. She didn't like they way they were staring and being so quiet.

She plays with the dogs

DISSOLVE TO:

El checks the time.

One hour left.

She summons the dogs and leashes them.

Made in Highland

Exiting through the barriers, Albie pulls from one side, Bo and Belle the other. This catches El off guard, and Albie gets free.

He's heading straight for the mud puddle, he dive-bombs into it.

The puddle swallows Albie, deceptively deep. And the more Albie moves to try and escape the quicker he's sinking into a thickening quicksand.

El jumps for his leash, which she can't quite reach without falling into the puddle.

Belle volunteers.

El tosses Belle into the puddle, leash in hand.

Belle bites down on Albie's leash.

Bo and El pull.

Belle's out, leash in teeth.

Albie escapes.

They shake clean. Sorta.

47 **EXT. SHARON'S APARTMENT** 47

Knock Knock.

No Answer.

Door's unlocked.

See you tomorrow, Bo.

JEANNIE (O.S.)
Who is in my house?! You don't just come into people's homes. Very rude!

El whips out her phone, typing to explain...

JEANNIE
Thanks! See you tomorrow!

Door slams.

Made in Highland

48 **EXT. COLLEGE KID'S DORM** 48

El hands off the leash to Zoe.

Somewhere near by, a loud thunderous woof.

Zoe slams the door closed.

El hurries to Sheen's, catching Gary and Jojo, also going home and trying to get El's attention.

49 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 49

As El finds the key to Sheen's place, Gary arrives at his apartment next door.

GARY
Hey! Did you hear me?

Albie and Jojo are face to face. Jojo is not playful.

GARY
Your dad said you're the best dog walker in town. And if you're walker her dog that must be true.

Gary doesn't notice how aggressive Jojo acts.

As if from nowhere, El produces her "he's not my dad" card.

GARY
Whatever.
(beat)
Wanna walk this guy for me? He needs the exercise.

Jojo has blood on his chomps.

El doesn't answer, and starts to calculate excuses.

Gary's phone rings.

El takes this opportunity to let herself into Sheen's apartment.

50 **INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 50

Gary knocks on the door.

GARY (O.S.)
I'll make arrangements with your dad!

Made in Highland

Time check. Twenty minutes.

BATHROOM

El washes Albie in the bath.

Mud cakes the bathtub.

Front door? She's home?

Albie doesn't notice, El freezes up.

SHEEN (O.S.)
Albie?...Albie?!...where are you? You're up my butt the second I walk in.

El towels Albie down. Behind her, the door opens.

SHEEN
Oh wow, someone's getting the royal treatment, huh?

El folds the towel, and head tucked down, tries to slip past Sheen.

SHEEN
Hey, hold up, chick--where you heading off to?

As El texts, her alarm goes off: "Dinner."

SHEEN
What's on the menu?

"I don't know."

El slithers away.

51 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EVENING** 51

El pulls a plate out from the microwave and joins Dave at the dinner table.

Dave takes a bite of his food...grimaces. He puts his plate back in the microwave.

DAVE
You think I should make your--Sandra, a plate? Probably should, right?

He fixes her a plate.

Made in Highland

Microwave beeps.

DAVE
(walking back to the table)
Don't tell you mom--dammit. Don't tell her that...

Sits back down, and starts chowing.

El looks waiting for him to finish.

DAVE
(taking a few moments to notice)
I think I like these frozen mashed potatoes better than hers. But you can't say that of course. Even when they ask. You'll see when you grow up and get married if you're stupid enough to fall into that trap. Not saying you're stupid obviously. Getting married is stupid. Or...could be stupid. Guess it just depends on who you're getting married to. I'm not trying to give you the wrong idea. Me and Sandra love each other. I'm just stupid. And I love you, and Sandra loves you, too. You'll find someone some day to take care of you. Uh, you know, not that you need taking care of.

Dave flings his hands in the air, and continues eating.

Beat.

DAVE
Oh yeah, I almost forgot to tell you that I got you another client. Gary. The guy next door.

No!

DAVE
Sweetie, money is money, right? It's not smart to turn down work.

No! No! No!

DAVE
Give me one good reason why not?

"He brings his dog to work and gets home too late!"

Made in Highland

DAVE
I don’t think that’s true.

El starts typing, but ultimately decides not to send the message. She gets up from the table and dumps her plate into the garbage.

DAVE
He said he hides a key in the patio light. I have a small ladder you could use to reach it.

About to leave--

DAVE
Oh yeah, before I forget--uh, you’re spending the night at the girl’s place across the way. What’s her name? You’re walking her dog, right?

El halts. Furiously types. Deletes.

“No way. Why?”

DAVE
Sandra’s aunt died and we need to go up north for the weekend.

“I’m old enough to stay by myself.”

DAVE
No. You’re not.

“Can’t you stay with me?”

“I’m not going.”

“I can take care of myself.”

DAVE
How would we look if we left a fourteen year old girl home alone?

“My friends stay home alone all the time!”

DAVE
Which friends?

“You wouldn’t know their names...”

DAVE
I’m glad you made some friends!

“Please don’t make me go.”

Made in Highland

DAVE
Okay, listen. I'll talk to Sandra.

52 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT - AFTERNOON** 52

Knock. Knock.

Sheen makes her wait, but not nearly as long as last time. She bares a warm smile as she opens the door.

SHEEN
You got a key, dontcha?

Sheen hugs El who shifts into a wet noodle.

SHEEN
We're gonna have fun.

Sheen lets El go, then goes back inside like nothing ever happened.

El stands frozen at the threshold, awkward.

53 **INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 53

El hears muffled barks as she stalks into the apartment.

SHEEN
In here!

El follows Sheen's voice into the

KITCHEN

Barking a bit louder.

SHEEN
Albie! Shut it won't ya?!
(to El)
I'm surprised he's not all over you right now...Oh, he might be locked in the bedroom.
(laughs)
Make yourself at home, I got a surprise for ya.

Sheen exits. El remains hovering awkwardly.

Albie's suddenly at her feet.

Made in Highland

SHEEN
Yo! I said make yourself comfortable.

Sheen grabs El's backpack off of her back and hooks it onto the back of a chair.

SHEEN
Now sit down and get hungry cause we're about to eat my Florida--if not the country, if not the world--famous mac-n-cheese. Homemade. Not the boxed stuff. There ain't now powder on these here ronies. And don't tell me you ain't hungry because I remember what they serve at school.

El takes a seat and a bowl slides from the other end of the table right in front of her.

Sheen returns with another plate for herself.

SHEEN
No need to wait for me. How is it?

El holds up a mouthful on the spoon, blows off some of the heat, then gulps it down.

She chows down on the bowl.

SHEEN
What better response could a chef ask for!

El finished her bowl, and notices Sheen playing with her food instead of eating it.

SHEEN
More?

Affirmative.

Sheen refills her bowl.

SHEEN
I'm gonna join you when you walk the dogs, if that's cool with you?

Affirmative.

Sheen slides the bowl across the table.

Ding.

Made in Highland

Sheen checks her phone.

Car alarms sounding off appear faint and grow louder and louder.

SHEEN
Hey. I'll be right back. Help yourself to more if you want. Don't feed fatty any.
(to Albie, dog voice)
"No, no, no, I can't eat human food because then I diarrhea all over the entire apartment!"

Sheen exits.

Fat bass beats the apartment, shaking the entire structure, an earthquake of beats.

Another spoonful, and then El checks out the blinds behind her, and watches Sheen get into the yellow race-car--

El chokes.

Then hurries to the fridge to grab some water.

As she guzzles down a drink, she looks over the polaroid splattered doors of the fridge.

Pictures are out of focus, weird angles. Partying.

Wow, she sure has a lot of parties.

Door opens and El hurries back to her seat.

Sheen walks right past the kitchen.

Bedroom door closes.

El finishes up her bowl of food, and cleans it in the sink.

SHEEN (O.S.)
You didn't have to do that!

Sheen grabs her full bowl from the table, dumps it into the pot, then shoves the pot into the fridge.

54 **EXT. GARY'S APARTMENT** 54

El, Sheen, Albie, Belle, and Bo shiver with fear outside of Gary's apartment. Jojo lets out bone chilling barks.

Made in Highland

SHEEN
You gotta walk <u>this</u> guy's dog?

Shrug.

SHEEN
How do we get in?

El points to the patio light fixture.

Sheen reaches into it and retrieves the key.

As El unlocks the door and turns the knob, the barking intensifies.

El build up all of her nerves, and swings the door open.

Barking stops entirely. The apartment, dark as can be, does not beg entrance.

El looks back to Sheen. Sheen grabs the leashes from El's hand and ties them to the railing behind them.

Grabbing El's hand, they bound into the darkness.

55 **INT. GARY'S APARTMENT** 55

Pitch dark.

Flick flick.

SHEEN
Lights are out. Ugh. I never wanted to be in here again.

Flashlights from their phones ignite simultaneously.

Pinned to the wall, a ripped letter, on the floor below it a leash.

The letter reads: "Here's a leash. And be careful cause [letter is shredded after that line]"

Low rumbling grow builds in the darkness. Sheen latches onto El, shrieking.

El grabs the leash on the floor, fighting Sheen's super tight grip--

Ruff!--El jumps out of her skin.

Spinning around on their tippy-toes, they see Jojo standing in line of them. Slobber and dribble drops onto the floor with big wet bloops.

Made in Highland

He digs his paws into the ground, gaining a running start and charges.

The girls scatter, separating in opposite directions, circling the dog and reconvening behind him.

Jojo crashes into the wall, leading a large concave in the drywall.

SHEEN
(out of breath)
Okay, maybe we just leave this guy behind.

Jojo charges again!

Sheen follows into the same pattern as before...but El, she stays behind, closes her eyes, and opens her arms--

Jojo tackles El to the ground, knocking the cellphone moonlighting as a flashlight out of her hand and rendering them in complete darkness.

In darkness, El shrieks and the dog feasts.

SHEEN
Where are you?!

Sheen flashes her light around the dark and messy room. The light beam passes over El, and Sheen gets closer to what she thinks is the death via eating alive of the one responsibility she took on for the weekend.

Sheen gets close, and then El laughs.

She ain’t getting eaten to death, she is getting licked to death.

DISSOLVE TO:

56 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - MOMENTS LATER** 56

With all dogs in tow, they make the move to head off, climbing down a flight of stairs toward the ground level--

Sheen sluggishly falls back.

SHEEN
I don’t think the food is sitting with me right. To think my world famous Mac would betray me...I’ll see you in a bit...

Made in Highland

El, clearly disappointed, watches Sheen stumble up the stairs. Raises an eyebrow, then carries on just as before.

57 **EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - AFTERNOON [FAST FORWARD 2X]** 57

El walks the mutts, but this ain't no dog park kinda day. She wants the dogs to go potty and to go potty quickly, so she takes them for a walk nearby.

At first, the dogs play and brawl, then they pull her with speed and vigor, but she regains control and instead of them walking her she is finally doing the walking.

El hands off the dogs to their owners.

58 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 58

El almost knocks--but catches herself.

She pulls out her key and lets herself in.

59 **INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 59

Albie darts into the apartment excited to be home.

He leads her to a closed door, and barks.

The door bursts open--air blows out with the power of the vacuum of space.

El grabs onto the door to hold on and grabs Albie's leash. Once the pressure stabilizes they return to the ground to peek inside the room.

A nighttime forest lit with the light of a full moon. Birds chirp, wolves howl, and rivers ebb and flow.

Albie don't need no invitation, and he's off into the wilderness having spotted something of interest.

El left behind and confused, sees that he is on the tail of a glowing White Stag.

Jumping through a brush, Sheen, now a warrior princess armed with a bow, pursues the same Stag.

Almost out of sight--

El dives into the painting.

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60 **EXT. MIDNIGHT FOREST - NIGHT** Ok, not that I don't like this part, but I'm like… WUT, Why? 60

El trails far behind Sheen, Albie, and the White Stag--the light guides her.

She runs through the dark brush, pumping her knees, breathing like mad.

The glow disappears.

And all of a sudden, El's toes are at the foot of a steep cliff. She teeters almost falling off the edge, but regains her balance.

Below her a large and still lake, amplifying the size of the moon until it feels like it's just within reach above.

El follows a footpath down to the lake, and just as she gets to a clearing--

Sheen grabs her and brings her behind a tree, silencing her.

Sheen points from behind the tree across the lake, "she's right there..."

White Stag darts between trees and feeling she has lost her enemies, stops to take a quick lick of water from the moonlit lake.

Sheen takes aim at the stag...

Locks it in her sights.

Disengages, and puts the arrow back into it's quiver.

SHEEN
Not bad.

61 **INT. SHEEN'S ART ROOM** 61

El and Sheen admire a spray painted canvas. A spray can hangs idly by Sheen's side.

SHEEN
Wanna give it a go?

Sheen opens a closet behind them.

"Me? No! Of course not, I couldn't do that...ah ha ha ha..."

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SHEEN
(muffled, fiddling in the closet)
You just need to tap into your instinct. Shut off your thinking brain.

Sheen sets up a blank canvas next to the canvas Sheen just finished rendering.

She grabs El's hand, and forces her to grab onto a spray can.

SHEEN
(shoving El)
Go on.

El frozen with possibility, looks to the blank canvas, then at Sheen's canvas. Back and forth. Back and forth.

Where to start?...

Hopeless...

She looks back at Sheen, "go on!"

El sprays a dot onto the canvas.

SHEEN
Okay, common.
(taking El's arm)
Push down on the button here...
(spray sprays)
And wave your arm like so...
(waves El's arm around)
Looks like a good background. Not that hard, right? Just keep on trucking, I'll be right back.

Sheen leaves, closing the door behind her.

As the door closes, El loosens up immediately. She stares into the canvas.

62 **INT. ANCIENT DOJO** 62

Japanese Dojo. All white. Everything is canvas.

El, donning a karategui, bows--

And then lets loose her spray paint nunchakus in a furious and assured fury. Paint, a different color on each nunchaku handle (4), flies and crashes all around her splashing onto the floor and walls..

Made in Highland

Door opens--

63 **INT. SHEEN'S ART ROOM** 63

El freezes in a low angled pose, both spray can cocked in each hand, breathing heavy.

As Sheen comes to look at her work, El quickly composes herself, standing at attention.

Sheen pats her on the back.

SHEEN
I got something you might like...

Sheen digs through her closet.

El reassess her canvas and Sheen's.

SHEEN
Ugh! Where is this thing!?

El goes to assist her, pulling out her phone and flashlighting the dark closet.

DISSOLVE TO:

64 **INT. SHEEN'S ART ROOM** 64

El shows Sheen some of her ink sketches, flipping through the pages. She nervously skips over some pages.

Sheen grabs the book from her hand, and starts flipping through the book at her own volition.

El tries to get the book back, but the attempts are half-hearted.

Sheen flips through renditions of the fantasized versions of the people El encounters on her day-to-day travels.

SHEEN
(re: Hugh)
Oh my god, he <u>is</u> a zombie. Yuck. A zombie who can't control where his eyes wander.
(still flipping)
You got one of me?...

El tries harder to get the book back, and nearly succeeds chasing Sheen around the small room, riling Albie up--

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Sheen makes a break for it, opens the door, and runs down the

HALLWAY

into the

LIVING ROOM

Sheen jumps onto the couch and El running after her falls on top of her, then onto the floor below.

When El goes to swipe the book one more time, Sheen's already found the page...

SHEEN
Wow...I'm way more gorgeous in ink.

El shrivels, grabbing her knees into her chest.

Sheen notices--hands her the book back.

SHEEN
You got an eye.

DISSOLVE TO:

65 **INT./EXT. SHEEN'S CAR - AFTERNOON [DRIVING]** 65

El, in a pleasant and relaxed mood, stares out the window, softly jamming to music. Sheen, lit cigarette in hand, jams harder, singing.

Is this the same world, though? I envision their lives as set in an intense, violent, and dangerous dystopia, and so the idea of them driving around pleasantly doesn't seem possible in this world

Ding.

El's not sure if it was her phone or Sheen's, but Sheen doesn't seem to notice.

Message from Mia...Uggggh...

She huffs, then ignores it, slipping the phone back into her pocket.

Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding.

El silences her phone.

SHEEN
My someone is popular.

"Nuh-uh."

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SHEEN
Who is blowing you up?
Your parents?

El texts: “They’re not my parents. And it’s some girls from school.”

SHEEN
You know this whole not talking thing makes communicating in the car very dangerous.
(checks her phone)
They’re not trying to see what you’re up to, huh?

“No.”

SHEEN
I used to get picked on too. Every year I had the same sneakers until the bottoms were worn away and water would get into them and make them all moldy and smelly. Then and only then, after I begged and pleaded, my mom would buy me new shoes. And you know, most kids parents take them school shopping right before the first day.
(beat)
What’s her name?

El texts: “Mia.”

SHEEN
(checks the message, the car swerves a bit)
Jessica Sword.
(beat)
Haven’t thought about her a day since the end of high school.

Behind them, a cop car puts on its flashers.

SHEEN
Not again! And in the same damn place too! If it’s the same cop as last time, I’m gonna flip.

Sheen reaches into her bra, pulls out something small that could fit easily into the palm of her hand--

SHEEN
Put this in your sock.

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Sheen reaches over, El holds out her palm. Sheen hands it off, and without looking, El folds it into her hand, and slips it into her sock.

Sheen pulls over.

DISSOLVE TO:

66 **INT. SHEEN'S LIVING ROOM - NIGHT** 66

Lights from a loud television dance across El's, Sheen's, and Albie's faces. El is lying belly down on the couch, Albie's on her legs. Sheen is passed out on the floor.

Ding. Another light joins the dance: Sheen's phone.

Sheen doesn't move for it, or move at all.

The light dies from the phone, and El's attention returns to the movie.

Beat.

Sheen scratches her face.

Ding.

Sheen remains unresponsive.

El looks for guidance from Albie. The light fades.

Settling back into the groove of the movie--

Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding. Ding.

El leans off the couch and over Sheen's corpse, almost able to see the phone...

Almost...

Almost--

She falls off the couch, and maneuvers to not fall directly onto Sheen.

Ding.

El looks--it's Frank.

His texts keep firing off like mad. But nothing is disturbing Sheen.

El picks up the phone and unlocks it.

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Text notifications continue.

Temptation.

She switches the phone to vibrate, closes the screen, and then places the phone face down back on the floor.

El grabs some blankets from Sheen's bedroom and returns to cover Sheen.

Everyone settles back into their starting positions. Equilibrium.

Car alarms sound off. Low thud of the chest bursting sub bass.

Bang Bang Bang at the front door.

Albie charges the door and barks.

FRANK (O.S.)
Open up!
(more knocks)
Open up! This ain't going to be the third time you do this to me! Open!!! Up!!!

Door handle shakes and jiggles.

El crawls out of her skin. Sheen still asleep.

SHARON (O.S.)
Hey! I called the cops! You won't wanna be here when they get here, pal.

Bang. Bang. Bang.

FRANK (O.S.)
Not the first. Might be the last.

SHARON (O.S.)
Next time you're here I'm reporting this license plate number, you get me?

FRANK (O.S.)
Whatever.

Frank kicks the door.

The sub bass withdraws, the car alarms are silenced one after the other.

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SHARON (O.S.)
(to Sheen)
I don't know what kinda place you think this is, but we are all getting sick of you and the people you're bringing around. There are ways to put an end to this that isn't as clean as calling the police.

Bang. Bang. Bang.

SHARON (O.S.)
You hear me?...Dark web. Comprende?

Sharon kicks the door.

Beat.

El peeks out of the blinds, watches Sharon leave.

El tries to calm down back on the couch, tries to refocus on the tv.

Sheen wakes up. She itches her face, and stretches.

SHEEN
(yawning)
This is my favorite part...nope, not yet. It's coming up soon. Not here. Yeah...oh shit! Yes, look at that face.
(getting up)
I'm gonna make some cookies in the oven...and maybe ice cream too. Sound good?

She leaves without waiting for a response.

DISSOLVE TO:

67 **INT. DINER - MORNING** 67

Sheen leads El and Albie to a table, and they take their seats.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS approaches.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
Uh, who seated you?

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SHEEN
(points O.S.)
She did.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
She didn't cause if she did, <u>it</u>
(pointing to Albie)
would not be sitting in here.

SHEEN
<u>He's</u> a--uh, what do ya call em?

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
Service dog?

SHEEN
Yeah!

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
Are you kidding?

SHEEN
I got the papers in the car. But do we really need to embarrass this girl...
(re: EL)
This dog is the only thing keeping you all alive right now.

Gum-Chewer looks at El, makes a sad face.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
What do you want?

SHEEN
Menus.

Gum-Chewer leaves in a huff.

Sheen smiles at El.

Storms back with menus. Dumps them on the table, takes out her pad and pen and taps her toe expectingly.

Without looking at the menus:

SHEEN
Banana pancakes.

"Same."

SHEEN
(holding up two fingers)
Two. And waters...and a coffee.
(MORE)

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SHEEN (CONT'D)
Got it?

Gum-Chewer writes the order and leaves without any eye contact.

Sheen fusses with her purse.

SHEEN
She's lucky I'm a server too. What a crank.
(beat)
What color nail polish?

She dumps a few on the table.

"I can't wear nail polish! Impossible! Not someone like me!"

SHEEN
(pushing three of her choices over toward El)
I think these would look good on you. Real choice.

While still nodding 'no,' she picks a color.

SHEEN
I was hoping you'd pick that one.
(beckoning for El's hand)
Gimme your hand. I bet I could get one hand done before she even brings the drinks.

Sheen paints El's fingernails on her left hand.

Gum-Chewer returns with drinks.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
You can't do that in here.

SHEEN
Why not?

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
It's policy.

SHEEN
It's policy to not allow a mom to paint her daughter's nails in the one hour per week I get to spend with her while the child services watches through the window from the parking lot?

Gum-Chewer walks away biting her lip.

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SHEEN
(to El)
Other hand.

El obliges.

SHEEN
(pantomiming)
Blow.

Sheen paints the right hand. El notices the Gum-Chewer conspiring in whispers with some compatriots across the diner. She returns, shaking, clearly with something to say.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
If...if. If you get any of that. Any of it. Any where. You're cleaning it!

SHEEN
Why are you telling me this for? I'm a professional. If anyone is gonna get any polish anywhere it's gonna be her. So why don't you say it to my dying daughter's eyes that she needs to scrub polish off your plastic tables with her poor weakened fingers.

Gum-Chewer storms off.

Sheen, not once breaking from the task, finishes the job.

SHEEN
Okay, blow on those now too. How do they look?...I'm enjoying this way too much.

In between all the blowing, El gives two thumbs up.

SHEEN
Now you're balling.

Pancakes arrive with a crash on the table. Gum-Chewer starts off--

SHEEN
Excuse me.

Gum-Chewer turns slowly...

SHEEN
Syrup, please?

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Gum-Chewer walks back towards the kitchen, they wait quietly, smirking, and back she returns with some syrup.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
(under breath)
You're welcome.

SHEEN
Thanks.

El pours syrup on her pancakes. And just as she is about to take a bite--

SHEEN
No, no, no. Sometimes you're the one spitting on people's food and sometimes your food is the food getting spat on.

Sheen places a twenty dollar bill on the table, and then with the polish, she writes: "5 Star Review."

68 **INT./EXT. SHEEN'S CAR - AFTERNOON [DRIVING]** 68

Sheen eats a McMuffin, and El eats hotcakes.

They pull back into the apartment complex.

El notices Sandra's car and shrinks.

69 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 69

Door opens. El exits.

Sheen comes out chasing after her, and grabs her from behind to give her a brief tight hug, then lets her go.

El turns around to give her a stronger and longer hug, letting go last.

70 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY** 70

El walks back home. Peeking back, she watches Sheen go towards Gary's apartment.

71 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 71

El enters to quiet. No one around.

As El walks towards her bedroom, she hears the quiet arguing of Dave and Sandra.

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She goes into her bedroom, and shuts the door.

DISSOLVE TO:

KITCHEN

El, Sandra, and Dave eat quietly around the kitchen table.

Dave works up the muster to speak:

DAVE
(to El)
Have a good weekend?

El doesn't respond. Eyes on the food.

DAVE
I told you it wouldn't be so bad.
Looks like you girls bonded.

El consciously hides her freshly painted fingernails.

SANDRA
Never in a million years did I think you'd wear nail polish. In fact, I think you even said as much.
(laughs)
My, how they change.

DAVE
They look nice! Don't be shy!

SANDRA
It's not the best color for her.

Having a Ladybird moment (in a good way). Assume you've seen it, but if not it'd be worth a watch to know what you do and don't want to do with El's character

El sits on her hands.

DAVE
(to EL)
I think you look nice.

SANDRA
Yeah, what do you know?

Dave jumps to frustration.

DAVE
A lot of things, actually,

SANDRA
Yeah?

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DAVE
Yeah.

SANDRA
Like?

DAVE
Like if a color looks good on my damn daughter's hands or not.

Is she his daughter or no?

Dave bangs a fist on the table and gets up to leave.

SANDRA
(pantomiming)
Look at me, I'm a big angry man!!!

Sandra looks to El for approval, El does not afford it.

Sandra sighs, finished her wine, gets up from the table, grabs the bottle from the kitchen and exits.

Moments later, the television is turned on in the living room. The volume rises until it's blasting.

El is left alone amongst half finished plates of food.

El pulls out her phone and navigates to Sheen's contact.

Her nail polished fingers begin to type away...

Love this moment

She deletes the message before sending it, and closes her phone.

As El finishes eating, the yellow race-car returns. She could only barely hear it over the sound of the tv until it's right outside, idling in the parking lot.

Peeking out the blinds: Frank takes the stairs three or four at a time.

He tries Sheen's door, and this time it's open. He lets himself in, and leaves the door wide open.

Hmm...

Soon he's back, he closes the door behind him, leaps down the whole flight of stairs, and takes off with fury screeching rubber.

Hmmmmmmmmm....???

El cleans the kitchen table, emptying the plates, and loading the dishwasher.

Washes and dries her hands.

Made in Highland

Sirens.

Louder and louder.

They don't pass by. They're outside.

It clicks.

And El runs to leave the apartment.

72 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY - NIGHT** 72

El kicks it into high gear, running towards Sheen's apartment, fumbling for the key ring, red and blue lights make her skip in time--

Key ring goes flying and slides down the hallway.

Three Police Officers stampede over the keys.

El retreats.

As El sneaks around the top level, going the opposite direction as before, in order to retrieve the keys--

Sheen's door gets busted down.

El climbs down to the

FIRST STORY

and hides near some vegetation to watch what unfolds from below.

Albie darts out from the apartment, barking his head off, and he finds El like he had a homing beacon.

MUSTACHIOED COP walks out of the apartment, hand in a crack of his shirt Bonaparte-style. He whistles and signals for the brothers in blue below to hang back and cut the sound of the sirens.

Other neighbors watch, confused.

El clams down. I mean if they're calm...right?

Albie yowls.

Another set of emergency lights come upon the scene, ambulance sirens blaring.

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73 **INT. EL'S BEDROOM** 73

El perches on the foot of her bed. Albie sniffs around the room. Sirens compete with the loudness of the tv in the living room.

She cries.

Then she doesn't.

Sirens cut out.

Yup, she's crying again.

Knock. Knock.

DAVE (O.S.)
Sweetie, you okay?...Wanna open up?
(upon the no answer)
I figured as much.

The TV cuts out.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Congratulations, you scarred her.

DAVE (O.S.)
I didn't--

SANDRA (O.S.)
I swear to god, don't so you didn't do anything.

Their bedroom door slams closed. Their argument continues albeit muffled.

DISSOLVE TO:

El and Albie asleep. Somewhere a tv still plays...

DISSOLVE TO:

HALLWAY

Light from a far off tv dance in the dark.

El's bedroom door opens; her and Albie sneak out.

LIVING ROOM

They tiptoe past Sandra asleep on the couch.

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AT THE FRONT DOOR

El unlocks the bolt lock and as she slides the chain lock, the TV gets real quiet...Sandra yells--mumbles...nothing...and the TV programming returns.

El slips out.

74 **EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT** 74

As she locks up behind her, she senses the presence of others.

SHARON

masked in darkness and shrouded in smoke, puffing away at a cigarette.

GARY

locks up his apartment, picks up two large garbage bags and a overnight bag tucked in each arm, and leaves in a hurry, checking behind him--

A light turns on as he passes it and he books it down a flight of stairs.

El makes eye contact with Sharon.

75 **INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT - FRONT DOOR** 75

El is frozen. Albie scratches and barks at Sheen's bedroom door.

KITCHEN

El finds Albie's food bowl.

HALLWAY

And walks toward the bedroom...

But can't quite go all the way.

She reaches forward the bowl to try and get Albie's attention...

He's not interested in food.

She places the bowl on the floor and slides it over to him.

Made in Highland

He continues to ignore it.

LIVING ROOM

El packs some of Albie's toys in a crate.

KITCHEN

Retrieves Albie's wet food from the fridge, closes the door--

And the Polaroids. Splattered across the entire fridge.

She stares at them, and now not under pressure of worrying being caught as too curious, really really stares at them.

They're sloppily taken. Nothing's in focus. Heads cut off. Some photos are nearly all just an entire thumb, or a soaked through polaroid now indecipherable.

Overhead lights strobe.

Four to the floor dance music bumps, every time the kick hits it disturbs the entire room.

Young adults and older teens file into the apartment.

El gets pushed aside as the fridge is opened and a continuous stream of beers are handed out.

She fights her way around the fridge and past the beer can line.

Three barely clad woman make out--Sheen push out from the threesome and El follows her into the

LIVING ROOM

SIDEWAYS-HAT keels over to vomit--

El slides under the arc of his vomit... You do these manic group scenes so well

On all fours she makes her way to a clearing, trying to evade being stampeded by dancing feet.

Flash. Camera shutters. Gary, sitting on the sofa, slips his hand up a young girls skirt.

Flash. Camera shutters. Walter sits cross legged on the floor in a circle of a few other girls.

Sheen dances in the clearing.

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Frank enters the clearing, grabs her by the arm and drags her away. Gary doesn't like this.

The crowd parts for them.

El follows in the wake of the parting.

HALLWAY

Frank and Sheen go into her bedroom, and just as El gets there the door slams. She tries to open the door, but she can't.

Gary dragged a girl into the hallway, and he bangs on Sheen's door.

Bang! Bang!

The door opens.

SHEEN'S BEDROOM

But there's nothing in there.

Just a disturbed bed.

She pulls out her flashlight and scans the bed. Moving some sheets around she finds a few drops of blood.

Opens a bedside table drawer filled with tiny plastic baggies. So many that she can submerge her hand in them. She pulls one out. It has a bunny on it. Another one, hearts. Another one, skulls.

76 **INT. EL'S BEDROOM - MORNING** 76

El scrolls through the evidence she collected on her phone.

Sandra knocks on her door.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Need a ride?

Moments later the front door closes.

Dave knocks on the door.

DAVE (O.S.)
Heading to Home Depot. Do you want me to drive you to school?

KITCHEN - LATER THAT MORNING

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El tends to schoolwork at the kitchen table.

Dave enters, bags in hand. He places them on the table, then sets up a pot of coffee.

Dave leaves the kitchen, and turns the tv on in the living room. Loud enough to hear, El identifies it as the news.

El whips out her headphones and plugging them in--

BEEP BEEP BEEP disrupts her--

Out the blinds a large truck carrying a dumpster is guided by brothers Mylo and ALEK (30s) and dropped off into the courtyard below.

Dave returns to the kitchen (wearing stained clothes).

El tries to ignore him as he grabs a cup of coffee and a bowl of cereal, and chows down at the table. The news still overpowers the music of her earbuds.

Dave says something to her she can't hear, she pulls out her earbuds, "what?"

DAVE
I was saying you're very studious.

She puts her earbud back in. And he talks again...

Earbud out, "what?"

So she did die? Maybe I read over it irresponsibly, but I wasn't sure of this

DAVE
I was saying that I'm impressed.
If I was you, I'd be grieving.
Inconsolable.

Back to work.

Dave gobbles the bowl down. Cleans up, deposits the bowl in the sink, and before he leaves--

El pre takes her earbud out. Dave smiles.

DAVE
(ruffling through a bag,
finds gloves, detaches them
from each other)
Don't work too hard. If you need me, I'll be right--I'm working near by. So text me if you need me. I'll see you in a bit.

Dave exits.

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El tries to refocus on her homework. But the tv...it's so damn loud.

Of course, he left the tv on.

She pulls away from the table and the headphones pop out, dangle from the table.

ANCHOR (O.S.)
...another breaking story. Another criss. But the same plague claiming our young and old alike.

LIVING ROOM

El searches for the tv remote.

ANCHOR (O.S.)
South Florida continues to be a hotbed affected by the opioid epidemic.

She finds the remote in a cushion crack.

ANCHOR (O.S.)
The how and why of our area's particular involvement--coming up.

She points the remote at the tv.

ANCHOR
But first--

Finger on the trigger.

ANCHOR
Another victim of the perpetual tragedy, Frank Lopez, or at-yellow-frank-five-six-six. Lost his wife to be just last night, and when we return he'll tell us just how hard the past eight hours have been for him--
(smiles)
after this.

El takes a crashing sit.

She stares idly at the commercials

and they blur

as the wheels in her brain

Made in Highland

click

click

clank.

ANCHOR
And we're back. If you've been watching we've been chronicling the opioid epidemic in South Florida. Last night, a husband to be, finds his wife dead...

Selfie video of Frank displays next to the Anchor:

FRANK
(holding a gun, muffled by helmet)
I ain't sleeping tonight, or any night for that matter until I find out who did this to my baby girl.

ANCHOR
That's some chilling stuff! And so what we're seeing here is a post from Frank Lopez just hours after Sheen White's death. We have Frank Lopez on the phone right now. Welcome Frank.

FRANK (O.S.)
(muffled)
Thanks for having me.

ANCHOR
You sound muffled.

It seems too convenient or familiar to me to have a realist news interview scene… if this is so common in the area, why would they interview Frank? Why not just report sensationally with clips of her apartment and heightening the drama of her death? I'd brainstorm what other scene might accomplish what you want to accomplish in this one in a less familiar way, or perhaps ratchet this news interview up to the point of surrealism, if that accomplishes what you want — El's dissociation akin to what she always felt walking around in the world before knowing Sheen.

FRANK (O.S.)
I'm wearing my helmet.

ANCHOR
Can you take the helmet off? The viewers need to hear you better.

Muffled sounds over the phone...

FRANK (O.S.)
Better?

ANCHOR
Better.
(down to business)
Mr. Lopez, police say Ms.
(MORE)

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ANCHOR (CONT'D)
White's case is a clear cut and dry fentanyl overdose. In your video memorializing the young woman, you make mention of foul play. Why?

Now THIS is interesting. I could see the news reporting on a video done to memorialize her, if it went viral or something. And I'd definitely want to see the video.

FRANK (O.S.)
It's very simple really...Because there was foul play. Duh! Someone took my angel away from me.

ANCHOR
Murder is quite the accusation.

FRANK (O.S.)
My baby had her problems. But--

ANCHOR
Doctor's Association of Medicine and Addiction says that is entirely normal for users to escalate their usage from sublingual administration to intravenous.

FRANK (O.S.)
She was afraid of needles.

ANCHOR
Mr. Lopez, witnesses say your car was seen at her apartment the afternoon Ms. White died. You also have a well documented volatile relationship, broadcasted by you on your social media account.

Video evidence of that volatile relationship begins to play on screen.

ANCHOR
If what you say is true, that there is in fact foul play, are you not worried that you then would become a prime suspect?

FRANK (O.S.)
I ain't got nothing to hide. And I ain't scared. What you are referring to are performance videos. We are performers, and if I showed you my analytics during out quote unquote fights...that be all the proof you need.
(MORE)

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FRANK (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Now listen, did we fight? Of course. But who don't? I just want the truth to be revealed and for justice to be served, and if I need to serve the justice I will do so.

I don't think you need this… I don't need to know how they fell in love because the relationship doesn't seem all that important to me (I think because it doesn't seem very important to Sheen, or El, in earlier scenes).

ANCHOR
Final question--do you remember the moment you fell in love with Ms. Lopez?

FRANK (O.S.)
Me and a few of my boys were driving back from Orlando four or five years ago and as we're pulling off the exit we see someone tagging underneath the overpass. And well we don't take kindly to--

Feed cuts out.

ANCHOR
Thank you, Mr. Lopez. That is all the time we have. Our thoughts and prayers are with Ms. White and her family--Next, we discuss with our panel of experts, whether or not selling super-heroin should be tried in court as murder or involuntary manslaughter. That's next. But first. Messages from out sponsors.

Click. TV shuts down.

Bang! Clang! Metal! Thunk!

Outside, through the blinds, El watches Alek dump some furniture from the second floor into the dumpster below.

Followed by Dave and Mylo carrying a larger piece of Sheen's art.

Oh no no no no no no no!

El ricochets out of the house.

77 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY** 77

She Sonic-the-Hedgehogs over to Sheen's.

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78 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT** 78

Dave exits, painting in hand, sees El rushing over.

DAVE
I told you to text if you need me!...You don't want to see this.

El grabs the painting out of his hands. And as Mylo files out next, she grabs the painting he's holding too.

Alek exits, and she tries to grab the painting he is holding too, but he easily holds it way above her head.

MYLO
Sweetie, what do you think you are doing?!

El attacks Alek like a feral animal, but he deters her just by holding a hand up.

MYLO
Ah, yes. You are the brat from before.

DAVE
Sorry, she's my daughter. She doesn't exactly talk.

Dave grabs her off of Alek's back.

MYLO
Control your brat, or you are gonna be out work, buddy.
(pointing to the cameras everywhere)
Don't make me call Julian.

DAVE
No, no. Of course not.

El, two painting recovered and tucked under arms, breathing heavy, stands behind Dave.

MYLO
Listen and listen with your little girl ears very good, and you listen too poppa.
(clears throat)
All this trash
(signals to Alek to toss the painting)
is our trash now.
(MORE)

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MYLO (CONT'D)
And me and my family, we like when trash lies with trash. So please, throw out the garbage in your arms. Or. You and your daddy can go home together right now. Bye bye.

El doesn't hesitate. About to toss them--

DAVE
(to El)
Stop.
(to Alek)
Have you heard the saying, "one man's trash is another...girls's treasure"?

MYLO
...

DAVE
How much do you want?

MYLO
A days pay.

DAVE
Deal.

Dave signals for her to go. She starts off to go.

MYLO
Hold it.
(she stops)
If they are treasure than indeed a day's pay is a bargain for both. The deal is...a day's pay for one.

El tosses one without looking at either of them at Mylo's feet and walks away. Mylo smiles and waves as she leaves.

MYLO (O.S.)
(to Dave)
Back to work! And cheer up, you're not the lucky owner of fine art. Now you can add 'investor' to your resume.

79 **EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 79

Before El goes back inside, she turns back to check on Dave. Alek shackles him in chains.

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80 **INT. EL'S BEDROOM** 80

Phone rings somewhere far off. El finds a place for the picture. She fights off tears.

Idea!

On her laptop, she finds the owner of the complex's email address.

She begins to compose an email.

LIVING ROOM

Phone continues to ring, as El secures Albie to his leash.

81 **EXT. BUSY STREET - AFTERNOON** 81

El bags ands ties a second bag of poop. Albie, Bo, and Belle in toe, but then--

Belle slips out El's hand and runs straight for the busy road.

Belle turns into a statue as a car is coming right for her, honking its horn.

El and poo crew run, and scoop her up, crossing to the other side of the road.

On the other side, El raises her arm to scold Belle, and Belle cowers and whimpers in fear peeing herself.

El soundlessly sobs.

DISSOLVE TO:

82 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EVENING** 82

The whole family back together at last. Dave moans periodically as though he had a very very hard day's work.

SANDRA
Did they say how much they were paying you?

DAVE
No.

SANDRA
Did you ask?

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DAVE
I'm sure it'll be worth it. They have me painting the next two days. By myself, I think, so I could turn it into three days if I try.

SANDRA
So you could be working for one dollar an hour and you'd have no clue. They don't even pay workers where they're from.

DAVE
Beggars can't be choosers.

SANDRA
You'd think a forty year old man--

DAVE
Don't round up. Thirty eight.

SANDRA
Rent's due next Wednesday. Are you going to be able to chip in so who knows, maybe I could have some money for myself and who knows maybe treat myself to a new outfit or a pedicure?

DAVE
Yeah.

SANDRA
(to El)
Why weren't you in school?

DAVE
She wasn't feeling good.

SANDRA
I asked her. You were feeling good enough to go walk your dogs. Sweetie, don't break yourself up over someone like her. She's no good.

El gets up to go...

SANDRA
Make sure you're in school tomorrow, and, uh...
(clears throat)

Dave resists the signal.

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She clears her throat again.

El stands, lip bleeding from biting it, fists clenched.

Dave continues his resistance.

SANDRA
The dog's got to go. He's messing with my sinuses.

El stomps and silently screams.

SANDRA
Oh, calm down. I'm not saying tonight. Within the week try and find him and home.

83 **INT. EL'S BEDROOM** 83

El's phone is on speaker, and it's ringing. Gary's voicemail picks up. El plays a message from her computer asking for his services.

El finds the news Anchor's email address.

Begins to draft an email, and she drags a folder titled 'Evidence' into the email.

Her phone rings.

Restricted number.

She almost declines the number--but picks up.

Heavy breathing.

JULIAN (O.S.)
Little American girls. Hello, cutie. Come to my office tomorrow night at midnight if you want to know what happened to your friend.

Hangs up.

El saves the email as a draft.

84 **INT. CLASSROOM - DAY** 84

Two indistinguishable RIOT GUARDS come through the door, grab El by her armpits, and drag her out.

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85 **INT. GUIDANCE COUNSELOR'S OFFICE** 85

The Riot Guards lay her down forcefully on a chaise lounge chair then take their position at the door.

Light clicks, a tiny lamp, just barely lights the COUNSELOR (80s) sitting at her desk behind El.

COUNSELOR
Your dad asked for me to ask you here. He said you needed someone to talk to. Lets see if we can get you to open up. What ails you, child?

El turns around to face the Counselor.

COUNSELOR
Do not look at me! Face the other way.

El reaches into her pocket for her cards. A long spider leg with a human hand on the end reaches forward and rips the cards from El.

COUNSELOR
No no no. None of that silly childish nonsense. This is grown up time.

El opens her backpack to take out a pad, a another spider hand pulls that away from her as well.

El peeks over the chaise lounge, the Counselor grows angry:

COUNSELOR
I don't think you understand. We want to hear your vocal cords and we want to hear them immediately. Now, there has been a sneaking suspicion around here, suspicions, if I had to wager, also held by your parents, that this whole not talking thing is
(with each word sheds her clothing and grows and grows, eight spider arms darting from each side)
one. big. act.

The Counselor now hovers over her, and slowly moves closer. El claws at her own throat, she can't breathe.

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COUNSELOR
Now listen and listen well. Nobody respects a liar and a fake. Now give up this immature games and talk like a human. We spoke with your doctor, no physical ailments. Let me ask you a very important question: where do you plan on going to college? And into what field? I'll have you know, not many industries seek out or have outreach programs for liars. Lets look at your file...
(a leg retrieves El's file)
I have a few options for you here.
(holds the file up to El's face)
And since you can't talk, why don't you point at the one you're interested in! Like an animal!

Someone knocks on the door.

COUNSELOR
I'm busy! Come back later!

El slips out from under her--

Runs--

COUNSELOR
Stop her!!!

Riot Guard One runs toward her, bending down to try and bear hug her, she uses his knee and then face as a launching pad, hops over the other guard and dives through the door's glass window and into her

86 **INT. EL'S BEDROOM - NIGHT** 86

Night prowler outfit.

87 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 87

El tiptoes past Sandra asleep on the couch.

As she unlocks the door--

Dave stumbles out from the bedroom wiping the sleep form his eyes.

El ducks into the

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KITCHEN

and slides under the table.

Dave enters, clicks on the light, pours himself a glass of water and

gulp
gulp
gulp.

Lights off, shuffles out, and the bedroom door closes.

As El slides out, Sandra stumbled towards her, so she retreats back under the table.

Sandra pours herself a drink, and sips it as she returns to the couch,

El waits awhile...

DISSOLVE TO:

88 **EXT. COLLEGE KID'S DORM - NIGHT** 88

Knocks gently.

Nothing.

She knocks hard!

ZOE (O.S.)
Come in!

COLLEGE KID CHORUS (O.S.)
(sloppily, out of sync)
Cooome iiiiiiin!

She tries the knob and it's open.

89 **INT. ARENA** 89

Darkness. Follow the cheer of thousands, what could be ten thousand, of fans screaming at the top of their lungs.

ZOE (O.S.)
In here!

COLLEGE KID CHORUS (O.S.)
In heeeeeeere!

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El banks around a corner--

Box-O-Popcorn holding, PIN-STRIPED wearing ATTENDANT rounds the corner simultaneously--

Popcorn flies in the air.

El tries to help him pick up the mess...

PIN-STRIPED ATTENDANT
No need. You've done enough.

He shoos her away.

ZOE (O.S.)
Place ain't that big!

Why UFC cage match?

Turning around she realizes she's at a UFC Cage Match. Two fighters knock the daylights out of each other.

In front of the cage, on a beat up sofa, TEDDY (27), Micah, and Omar.

ZOE (O.S.)
Hey.

Zoe is on the floor right next to El studying. Patrons step over her.

ZOE
Aren't all these apartments like replicas?

Shrug.

Crowd uproar!

Blood splashes across El's face.

...

0.0

!!!!!

ZOE
Boys...

EMILY (24) steps over Zoe.

EMILY
(to Zoe)
Who she?

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Not waiting for the answer joins the boys. Turns to Teddy to speak--

TEDDY
Ay! You're not glass moron!

She then moves to stand directly in front of his line of sight, then sends evil eyes.

One fighter over takes the other with a repeated 'cheap' move over and over.

OMAR
Yes yes yes yes yes yes yes yes yes yes yes!!!

ZOE
(sotto voce)
Here we go...

TEDDY
Aw come ooooon!

EMILY
How many times do I have to tell you not to call me a moron.

TEDDY
You're not a moron. Now move.

Emily grabs the remote. Click. Lights out.

TEDDY
Seriously?!

Given where we're at in the narrative, I'm pretty spent on meeting or getting to know "new" characters at a deeper level. I really want to see things play out for El

Click. Lights On. Fighters frozen.

OMAR
Paused it.

TEDDY
Not without taking some cheap shots.

Omar resumes the game. Takes a few cheap shots.

TEDDY
You are such a cheater!

Teddy's fighter gets his gut kicked in just as he's able to pick up his controller.

TEDDY
Lucky...for...me--you suck--Ha!!!

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Flying roundhouse back-kick knocks Omar's fighter's block off.

Blood splashes all of them.

El tries to retreat but it gets her and gets her good.

Zoe hands her a towel, she herself is clean.

ZOE
You'll learn.

Omar's fighter tries to get back up, but that's hard without a head.

Teddy wins!

OMAR
Yeah...but, your girlfriend called next.

Omar gets up from the couch, drops the controller behind him, fist-bumps Micah, takes a seat a beanbag chair. Teddy exits. The arena is silent.

ZOE
It's gonna be hard to get them to acknowledge you. Now might be your chance.

El gulps and slowly approaches.

Teddy and Emily enter, he's dragging her by her wrist.

TEDDY
You said you get winner so now you gon' get winner.

EMILY
You're really on my last nerve.

OMAR
Use that aggression and rein victorious!

TEDDY
Good luck. I won with a cheater and an interference.

MICAH
I call next.

El tries to get their attention as:

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Emily and Teddy select characters. The fighters change shape and form in the ring as they cycle through selections. Teddy chooses quickly. Emily keeps cycling...

She settles--

Nope. Maybe him. No her. No...

TEDDY
Pick!!!

She cycles.

TEDDY
EM!!!

She picks the first one she settled on.

El almost pokes or prods each of them.

Fight starts. Crowd roars back to life.

On both sides of their flank, El tries to wave them down.

Everyone’s phone pings.

EMILY
Was that my phone? Don’t look at it!

TEDDY
It was mine.

OMAR
It was mine.

MICAH
Huh?

El got the message to. She reads it. Micah turns around to look for Zoe and El’s presence startles him.

MICAH
Oh! Hi?

They shake hands meekly.

Teddy and Emily can’t remove their eyes from the fight--too much is on the line.

TEDDY
What’s going on?!

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MICAH
A girls here.

TEDDY
What girl?
(looks)
...oh.

Emily slaps his head. The fighters flail about for a moment.

TEDDY
Ow.

EMILY
Who is she?

Zoe comes closer.

ZOE
El, our neighbor.

OMAR
Oh, she walks the--

TEDDY
Wait, walks the what?

OMAR
She walks dogs. All dogs. The famous dog walker.

TEDDY
Is that why Bo's been losing weight?

ZOE
He needed to!

EMILY
How dare you! All of you!

TEDDY
You got some nerve.

El texts them, all the phones go off.

EMILY
Is that my phone? Don't look at who it is. Don't you dare.

ZOE
Yeah, he lives a bit down the way.

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EMILY
(oblivious)
Who?

TEDDY
Was that my phone?

ZOE
(to Emily)
Gary.

EMILY
Oooooh. Gross. Like major yuck.

MICAH
He sells the worst weed.
The worst.

OMAR
Old people always do.

ZOE
He aint old.

TEDDY
Too old to be going to high
school parties.

MICAH
(to Emily)
Something happened with you guys?

EMILY
Uh, gross.

TEDDY
He tried to kiss her. And she, you
know, stopped it.

EMILY
Yeah. Right.

TEDDY
Is she here trying to rile
up gossip?

El sends another text.

EMILY
Is that my phone?

ZOE
It’s everyone’s phone!

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MICAH
He has the sweetest car. Ev-er.

OMAR
BASSSSS!...infamous.

TEDDY
No no no no no everyone, stop running your traps. Who is this girl <u>really</u>?

El dodges a blood splatter behind the couch.

TEDDY
I'm not saying another word, and no one else should neither, until she tells us why she here. Matter of fact. You have until I kill my girlfriend...in three...two...uh...three...twooooo oooo...and...one!

Match ends. Everything goes quiet. Background loop funk jazz on speed plays looped.

El texts them again.

Emily gets up to get her phone.

ZOE
Em, your phone.

EMILY
(exiting)
I. heard. it.

MICAH
Her parties were the best.

OMAR
Oh, yeah! Remember when--

TEDDY
Shut up!

Micah and Omar take positions on the couch and start a match.

TEDDY
This ain't none of your business. Now leave and stop walking Bo. I'm about to go heat up a hot pocket. When I'm back you better be gone.

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90 **EXT. COLLEGE KID'S DORM - NIGHT** 90

Door slams on El. Seconds later, Zoe opens it a crack.

ZOE
You can still walk Bo. Same rules as before.

Door closes. Then opens again.

ZOE
Sorry.

Her phone rings--

Facetime...

Frank!!! Just then the rev of his engine somewhere not too far away.

FRANK
(waving gun around)
Why you speaking my name in a manner that is unbecoming--

She cuts off the call.

91 **INT./EXT. RIDESHARE - NIGHT** 91

DRIVER
Cold or the air okay?

El thumbs up. Smiles.

She calls a number.

Voicemail--

GARY (O.S.)
Hola. This is G and S. We're closed for the next few weeks. Don't go looking for no other lawn care cause we'll be back real soon!

Hangs up.

DISSOLVE TO:

Made in Highland

92 **EXT. DRIVEWAY - NIGHT** 92

Rideshare pulls up a driveway passing a massive opulent water fountain and trees decorated with Christmas lights.

Road goes on and on further and further from civilization.

Fog grows thicker.

In the distance a flame.

93 **EXT. GUARDHOUSE** 93

Guardhouse --> moat --> fortress. Walls too high to see behind.

Car stops. El gets out. Car leaves.

At the guardhouse, a masked and machine-gun wielding MOAT GUARD.

El points a thumb at the moat.

MOAT GUARD
I.D.?

"No."

Oh, wait...

She digs out her school i.d.--hands it over.

Moat bridge lowers.

Very

slowly.

Pterodactyl eclipses the moon and shrieks.

Hummer pulls onto the bridge.

Moat Guard offers her no guidance, so...

She walks over to the Hummer, and its door pops open, knocking her nearly off the bridge--

She hangs on the door--

Prehistoric Alligator jumps up from the moat water and tries to snatch her.

As she climbs her way back in, the car speeds backwards, knocking her out almost once more.

Made in Highland

94 **INT./EXT. HUMMER** 94

She gets in, and shuts the door with a slam.

And buckles up!!!

Russian Opera blasts in the car.

El can't make out the driver, he's just a large shape. Two leather hands grip the wheel.

The fortress is far off in the distance. The car careens along a single path, vicious jungle on both sides threaten to swallow the car whole.

Jungle lets out onto a long bridge with two banks of moonlit swamp on both sides--the light ignites the eyes of a thousand hungry alligators.

SKREEECH!

Car halts.

Driver turns his brights on--Massive prehistoric momma gator!

Driver hops out of the car, and jumps into a wrestle with the momma gator.

Lights reveal the shape to be Alek. He quickly overtakes the gator, and swinging three times on his heels, launches the gator via its tail back into the swamp from where it came.

Alek gets back into the car, kicks the vehicle into high gear, and suddenly they're at another gate--

It opens as he speeds through.

95 **EXT. MANSION - NIGHT** 95

Fifteen KGB OFFICERS, armed with AK47s, hike by admits a training protocol.

Twenty sports cars line the driveway.

Alek halts to a stop.

El's door pops open--

Opera from the cars speakers clash with

Torso crushing four-to-the-floor 808 kicks playing from inside the mansion. 808 Kicks send seismic waves through the landscape, making everything shake and come undone.

Made in Highland

Alek shoves El from the car and the kick waves send her flying--

She grabs onto a blue convertible.

Alek gets out from the car, the music not able to move him, and he grabs El by the scruff of her neck and as he carries her towards the mansion,

the front door opens.

96 **INT. MANSION** 96

Strobe lights stutter every movement.

El is left alone,

the bass beats her from all directions,

her insides are getting ripped up.

She finds a door--

Blue light floods out...

Two BOUNCERS block the entrance of what looks like a super happening night club. El scans the room, and she doesn't see any men.

BOUNCER
In or out?

The OTHER BOUNCER holds up two hands, a different baggie in each palm.

El stumbles backward, the door slides closed.

Back in the strobe maze...

Crawling--

Another door.

Bright white blinding light!
Flashes
And a scream.
Bare Legs.
A cry for help!
Duct tape.
Metal tools.

She slams the door closed!

Made in Highland

El falls back onto the floor, she slams her fists into the ground.

She crawls back...

Wherever she thinks the front door might be...

Yes!

Won't open!

Heavenly light descends from above...

Crystal chandelier.

Atop the grande staircase, JULIAN (19), dark-haired all-smiling Lucifer. He dons silk robes, and little else.

He descends with much pageantry, the light follows him, and as he gets near the music goes dead quiet. From nightclub to ballroom.

JULIAN
Hope you found the place alright.
I'm glad you've come, I've been
looking forward to meeting you.
Let me get a better look at you.

He gently pushes her chin up to better see her face...

Twirls her around.

JULIAN
What an innocent beauty!
(crossing his arms)
Business first, I suppose.

Julian waves a hand and a secret passageway opens up.

JULIAN
After you.

SECRET PASSAGEWAY

Red velvet hallway. Light far in the distance. Julian hovers right behind her as they walk. She wants to look back, but doesn't.

JULIAN
Not much further.

DISSOLVE TO:

Black metal door.

Made in Highland

Julian brushes passed El, slight pushing his body into hers as he passes...

He unlocks the door, and slides it open with some might.

SURVEILLANCE ROOM

Wall of television screens. Single leather loveseat.

JULIAN
(gesturing to the chair)
Please.

El sits. Julian makes some noise out of her line of sight. She tries to peek without seeming deceitful.

Julian sits on the arm of the loveseat, hands El a water.

She takes a sip.

JULIAN
(tips the bottom of her cup up)
Gulp gulp, little dove.

He finishes his water too.

Remote appears in his hand. Click. TVs come to life.

JULIAN
Ah, so many cameras and so much for us to see together.
(cycling through feeds)
Sometimes I'll just sit down here and for hours and watch.

TVs focus in on El's apartment complex...

Her front door...

Sandra asleep on the couch...

Dave sleeping...

JULIAN
(facing El directly)
What dates did you say?

Julian gets up off the arm chair, and stands directly in front of her. Lifting the remote to point behind him--click--

Moans and groans of pleasure from adult films. Multiplying one screen at a time. Or moans of pain or fear? They mix and confuse each other.

Made in Highland

El tries to get up, but he violently shoves her back onto the chair.

El does all she can to focus on Julian, not daring to look in the background, her eyes squint to keep it all out of focus.

JULIAN
Let me ask you a question. Before you meet my family, would it be not the gentlemanly things for me to meet your parents?

Crying now, she tries one more time to escape.

Nope.

JULIAN
You’re starting to feel it, right? That’s why we crush it and put it in the water.

Door opens--

Alek...

JULIAN
(to Alek)
Just in time. Bring her to my room. Set up the camera. We’re going to make a home movie tonight.
(kisses El on the cheek)
If any of the other girls are mean to you it’s only because they’re jealous you’re so very young.

Julian appears down another secret door.

Alek locks El in a bear hug.

SECRET PASSAGEWAY

Alek returns down the hall. Music gets louder. El is compliant, calculating.

Julian runs from behind, he’s yelling, but his voice is muffled by the music. And Alek seems pretty deaf.

El smirks to Julian, waving the remote she stole.

She turns into a feral cat and stabs Alek in his eyes with her thumbs.

He drops her.

Made in Highland

She slides on her knees into the

FOYER

And spins around in time to lock them both in the secret passageway.

97 **EXT. SWAMP - NIGHT** 97

Booking it across the bridge, she tosses the remote to the gators.

She runs.

And runs.

And runs.

98 **EXT. MOAT** 98

She finds a hiding spot by the drawbridge.

She waits.

And she waits.

And she

Falls

asleep.

MORNING

Horn honk.

Wakes her up, the bridge lowers.

El hustles, and hides behind the car, running with it as it crosses over.

El trips and falls off the edge--

Gators snap at her feet.

She grabs on with one hand and the bridge starts to lift--

She tries to pull herself up...can’t. Strength ain’t there anymore.

Made in Highland

When the bridge gets to a certain height, she falls over onto the other side, with a crash that knocks her unconscious.

DISSOLVE TO:

Wakes up.

Guard is jamming to some music and cleaning his weapon.

She waltzes right by him without him blinking an eye.

99 **EXT. STREET - MORNING** 99

El texts someone.

LATER

A car pulls up.

100 **INT./EXT. DAVE'S CAR [DRIVING]** 100

Drive home silently.

PULLING INTO THE PARKING LOT BACK HOME

DAVE
You know I have to tell her.

They get out of the car.

El hurries around and gives Dave a hug.

101 **INT./EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - MORNING** 101

El meanders to the bus stop, waits, rides, gets off, walks to school, responds to attendance, math class, history, English, lunch, bathroom, recess, biology, homeroom.

102 **EXT. SCHOOL - AFTERNOON** 102

School bell rings...

Doors spread open and the student body bustles out.

El patiently works her way, staying in line, waiting her turn.

She decides not to get on the bus, walks around the bus, and crosses the street.

Made in Highland

Gunfire sprays.

El knows what's what...

As she turns around an old revolver gun slides into her feet.

103 **EXT. OLD WEST TOWN SQUARE - HIGH NOON** 103

Not far away and closing the gap, Mia, her gang, and the rest of the school. And oh yeah, Mia's got a gun.

MIA
(gesturing to the tossed revolver)
Go on.

El picks it up. Examines it. Cocks it.

EMILY (O.S.)
No. This is stupid!

El starts towards Mia...

MIA
Stay there!

El advances, tosses the gun aside.

MIA
I said--

Mia fires.
Misses.
Fires and
misses.
Hits!
Hits!
But they don't stop her.

The gap between them whisperable--Mia's gun in El's face.

Mia fingers the trigger--

Emily knocks Mia's gun-wielding hand and the loosed bullet eats gravel.

El wraps her arms around the stunned Mia.

Crowd gasps.

Mia resists. And for a second, just one, gives in...

El lets go, and does not linger. She exits.

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104 **EXT. STREET - AFTERNOON** 104

EMILY (O.S.)
Hey! You okay?

Emily catches up to El.

EMILY
I should've stepped in sooner. Tried, or something...I've known her my whole life. She used to be different. I know that's not an excuse or anything.

Okay.

EMILY
Hey, you know where you're going to school yet after this?

...

EMILY
I wanted to go to Gainesville, but I got rejected so now I'm stuck in Broward with Mia.

...

EMILY
You're a good listener.

Eye roll.

EMILY
We should go to the mall, or something?

No thanks.

105 **INT. BUS** 105

Hugh gets on the bus and does his whole routine.

Once settled, it takes a minute for him to notice her.

He waves.

She waves back.

"Come on over," he gestures.

No thanks.

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"Come on, come sit next to me," he waves.

No. Thanks.

This confuses him greatly.

106 **EXT. STREET** 106

Hugh, bags in hand, walking slowly. El takes great pleasure in moving around, and surpassing, him.

HUGH
How rude.

She continues to make the gap between them--

107 **EXT. RACE ENDZONE** 107

She breaks through a blue ribbon, winning the race, grabs a little paper cone of water, downs it, and high-fives a group of People waiting around for the winner.

108 **INT. SHARON'S APARTMENT** 108

El finishes her homework in the kitchen.

Leashes Albie.

109 **EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS** 109

Not Jeannie not Walter open up for El...

Zoe nor the Boys answer...

El walks Albie. They take their time.

El receives a text.
Ignores it.
Continues the walk.

Another text, which she thus ignores.

The soothing walk continues. Ending on its natural conclusion. Not a moment earlier.

110 **EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - EVENING** 110

El ascends the stairs.

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111 **EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 111

OFFICER DARYL (40s), Hugh, Sharon, Jeannie, Frank, and Gary crowd outside of the front door.

112 **INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT** 112

El comes into the house, the crowd behind her.

SANDRA
(hearing the front door open)
Where have you been? You know the rule and you still missed dinner. You made us wait. You didn't answer our texts. For all we knew, you could've been dead.

El walks into the living room.

LIVING ROOM

Sandra and Dave sit in the same almost touching couches, but very far apart, not even nearly touching.

SANDRA
Do you have any idea--

Crowd files in behind El.

DAVE
Should I make hour d'oeuvres?

113 **INT. COURTROOM** 113

OFFICER DARYL
Presiding over this hearing is the Honorable Judge Daryl. Ladies and gentleman, please rise.

JUDGE DARYL enters the courtroom in judge clothes, and takes his seat behind the bench.

JURY of plainclothes DARYLs file in, and take their seats in the jury box.

JUDGE DARYL
Prosecutor Daryl, your opening remarks, sir.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Thank you, your honor.

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PROSECUTOR DARYL stands from behind his desk and makes his way to the open space before the Judge, and approaches the Jury..

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Ladies and gentleman of the jury, the Defendant has cause all sorts of trouble. Evidence and testimonies will prove that the Defendant is a disturber of the peace, a vigilante, a libelous blogger, and most of all, and most importantly a little girl who needs to learn her place in this world. The state is certain that a guilty conviction on multiple counts: one libel, two disturbing a crime scene, three, not respecting the elders or the law, four, not going to church and being a good Christian, and five, not responding to her parents in a timely matter. With your help, ladies and gentleman of the jury, we can really teach this child a lesson. Thank you. That's all you honor.
(returns to behind the his desk.

JUDGE DARYL
Will the State be going after the maximum sentence?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
The State hopes to get her to drop the whole not talking act, your honor.

JUDGE DARYL
Maximum sentence noted.
(to El)
And the defense?

Running narratives I see in the screenplay:
1. El's silence
2. El and Sheen
3. Opioid use

^ I think it's worth sieving your scenes through the top narratives you intend, to see how you can condense them to support those narratives. Otherwise, some scenes (like the forest, like the moat, like the crazy dystopia commute to school, etc.) aren't interacting with these narratives in a way that I understand or pick up on. (Though I love them.) That could be my missing something, or it could be something you refine further so that each one is contributing or interacting toward your larger themes

She is not sure what to do. Freezes.

JUDGE DARYL
Miss?

Stutters as she stands up from her seat, approaches the Jury box with her hands in her pocket, pulls out her deck of cards, and sifts through them, pulls one out and hands it to the Jury.

FIRST JUROR takes it, makes note, hands it down the line. And so on and so forth. Waves of concern, or snooty indifference, but mainly suspicion, wash over them.

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On the way back to her seat, she stops in front of the Judge and bows, then quickly retreats back to her seat.

LAST JUROR hands the card to OFFICER DARYL. He walks it over to the judge, peeks, rolls eyes, and hands it over.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Objection, your honor! Secrets, secrets, are no fun, unless you share with everyone!

JUDGE DARYL
Sustained!--Er, overruled...
(reading the card, rolls eyes)
Let the record show that the card the Defendant handed to the jurors has a hand-written message reading: 'it wasn't me.'
(to El)
Very lovely handwriting. You plea not guilty?

El darts to a stand, both hands on the desk, nodding "YES!"

Crowd murmurs.

JUDGE DARYL
Now was that the wisest choice? This won't play well to our adult demographic.

El sits back down, not defeated.

JUDGE DARYL
Counsellor, your first witness.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
The State calls Hugh and Barb as its first witness.

Hugh approaches the stand, hacking up a lung.

HUGH
Barb, couldn't make it, and she wanted me to apologize, your honor.

JUDGE DARYL
(reaching over the bench to pat him on the back)
That's quite alright. Thanks for being here. We'll get you home soon.

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HUGH
(pulls a folded piece of paper out of a pocket)
I do have her note however on the matters at hand.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
That won't be necessary.

HUGH
You tell her that.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Sir, when did you first become aware of the Defendant's existence?

HUGH
Aware?...They adopted five four eight, I think eight or nine years ago. It had to be eight cause my prostrate went into remission. The cancer, you know.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
And did the parents tell you they adopted her?

HUGH
No, they didn't. But you don't give birth to an eight year old, do you?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
No.

HUGH
This was all in my wife's letter by the way.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Alright, sir, so wen did you realize she was a little brat?

HUGH
I'd say about three hours ago.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Okay, take whatever time you need, sir, but can you walk us through it?

HUGH
I'm an old man--

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PROSECUTOR DARYL
Yes, go on...

HUGH
And I'm walking to the bus stop with two arms full of groceries. The cold cuts are getting squashed, the rye irreparable. I made a sandwich it was mush. The liverwurst, let me tell you something, Jaron, the colored boy, cuts my wife perfect slices of liverwurst.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
When does the defendant come into this?

HUGH
Sure sure sure. I'm carrying a million bags, walking up hill, and I'm waiting for the bus. I think I'm going to topple over at this point. So I'm waiting and I'm waiting and as the bus finally pulls up, I get on, of course, and I notice her sitting on the bus sitting their reading.

Crowd murmurs.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Reading?

HUGH
Reading. Other times I've seen her doodling--

Crowd gasps. Judge Darryl bangs his judge hammer.

JUDGE DARYL
Order. Order.

HUGH
And so, of course, knowing all the while in my head that since she is young and her time is much less important than my time, I ask her for help.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
But she doesn't--
(slamming the desk)
does she!?

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HUGH
No, she doesn't. That's what is so very concerning. She has always said yes before with out any lip. Just like that she declines me, flipping like a light switch.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
What were the defendants words when you, and very very very very very old man, asked for the child's help?

HUGH
"No."

Prosecutor Daryl lets it sink in.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
No, ladies and gentleman. No. This is the type of person who thinks she could say no. Imagine a world...
(to Judge)
That'll be all your honor.

JUDGE DARYL
(to El)
Defense, your witness.
(sotto voce, to Officer Daryl)
Though, I don't see the point.

Judge and Officer laugh to themselves. Crowd laughs after them, but at what, they're not sure.

El stands up, nods "No!"

JUDGE DARYL
(to Hugh)
You're dismissed. Send your wife our regards.

Hugh, talking under his breath, grumbling, exits.

JUDGE DARYL
Your next witness?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
The State calls Jeannie, local baker, and another character witness.

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JUDGE DARYL
Another character witness?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Another character witness.

JUDGE DARYL
Why?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
The State is building an impenetrable case by first assassinating the Defense's character.

JUDGE DARYL
Sure, but don't you think we've all seen all we need to see in that department?

....

JUDGE DARYL
Fine.
(to Jeannie)
From your seat then Jeannie, why don't you stand up and tell us what you don't like about the Defendant?

JEANNIE
Your honor, I am a holy woman, as I am sure you are a holy man, and anyone of good character goes to church. I have been trying to get the child to come back with me to Sunday mass for the past month.

JUDGE DARYL
(to Prosecutor)
Anything?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
I'm good.

JUDGE DARYL
(to El)
Any questions?

Nope...

JUDGE DARYL
(to Jeannie)
Thank you, please be seated.
(MORE)

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JUDGE DARYL (CONT'D)
(to Prosecutor)
Counsellor, let's keep this thing rolling. Next witness?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Your honor, will the State be permitted to call the witnesses it sees fit or will the court continue to interfere?

JUDGE DARYL
Counsellor, you and I both know, we all want to get to the juicy stuff.

Prosecution reviews documents.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
State calls for a short recess in order to trim the fat from the the witness list.

114 **INT. COURT HALLWAY** 114

Prosecution dismisses Frank, Gary, and Walter.

Down the hall, El throws a silent tantrum.

DAVE
I was wondering why they were even here.

Facepalm.

115 **INT. COURTROOM** 115

PROSECUTOR DARYL
State calls...
(spinning around and points)
the Reporter!

The REPORTER (30s) sat in the last bench, in the shadows, notebook and pencil out. She stops writing and makes her way to the bench.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Missus--

REPORTER
Missus.

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PROSECUTOR DARYL
Missus?

REPORTER
...missus...

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Missus Reporter. How long ago did the defendant reach out to you?

REPORTER
That is private information.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
How did she contact you?

REPORTER
Private.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Object, your honor! Everything can’t be private. We must know the truth!

JUDGE DARYL
Missus Reporter, please answer the questions to the best of your ability.

REPORTER
Okay.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
What was the content of the message or messages?

REPORTER
Confidential.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
(slamming desk)
Were these photos solicited?

REPORTER
Who said anything about photos?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Your honor, the State asks that the court to force Missus Reporter to read aloud to the good people of the jury the messages back and forth between the Defendant and Missus Reporter.

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JUDGE DARYL
Miss--

REPORTER
Missus.

JUDGE DARYL
Missus...Reporter, we implore you to relay the content the defendant shared with you.

REPORTER
Not without a subpoena.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
So let me get this straight!
(spittle flies from his mouth, he's losing it)
You receive unsolicited content talking about murder and conspiracy and making wild accusations from a fourteen your old girl and your first instinct is not to contact the police but to write an op-ed about it masquerading as fact?!?!

REPORTER
What's your question?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Objection, your honor. The question was clear.

JUDGE DARYL
Sustained. The question was clear.

REPORTER
Can you repeat the question please?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
(pleading)
Your honor?

JUDGE DARYL
Answer the question.

REPORTER
What is the question?

JUDGE DARYL
(to Court Stenographer Daryl)
Read the question back, please.

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COURT STENOGRAPHER DARYL looks through the notes...

STENOGRAPHER DARYL
I believe the question as posed was ‘what is wrong with you?’

REPORTER
I don’t believe that’s what was asked.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Those were my exact words!

REPORTER
Did any of you read the article?

El slams her fist onto the desk.

Shock catches like wildfire and spreads through the crowd.

JUDGE DARYL
What do you object to?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Objection! I object her objection!

JUDGE DARYL
Overruled.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Your honor, the State has the right to head an answer from its star witness in this capacity--

Reporter seems to be missing.

JUDGE DARYL
Prosecution, next witness?

PROSECUTOR DARYL
State calls the Defendant.

No.

JUDGE DARYL
Please approach the stand.

No.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
The State doesn’t mind questioning the brat right where she stews.

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DAVE
Hey! Go easy on her!

SANDRA
(hushed)
Sit down!

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Why do you think it was appropriate to meddle in the state's affairs?

No.

PROSECUTOR DARYL
Breaking and entering. Disturbing a crime scene.

DAVE
Where's the proof?!

PROSECUTOR DARYL
(turning to Dave)
Did you sleep through the testimonies?

JUDGE DARYL
Order!

SANDRA
(to Dave, yanking on his arm)
I said sit down!

Cut to Black. Door slams.

116 **INT. SANDRA'S LIVING ROOM - RIGHT BEFORE SUNSET** 116

El and Sandra face off. Dave returns into the living room...

He sits next to El.

SANDRA
He
(pointing to Albie)
needs to be gone by tomorrow.

Dave puts his hand on El's shoulder, sighs, and just as he turns to say--

El stops him, urging him aside, she sits up...

She mouths--*No*

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